

Philosophy of Religion

Religionsfilosofi

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Alte dubitat, qui altius credit.

(He doubts more deeply who believes more deeply.)

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Preface to the Third Edition

When I worked out my *Philosophy of Religion* in the years 1896–1901, I had not yet given any fuller account of epistemology. Nor had I arrived at one when the second edition was due to appear (1906). Later I set out my epistemological position in “The Human Thought” (1910) and in a series of investigations bearing on the subject of the present book (on Totality 1917, on Relation 1921, and on Analogy 1923). It has thereby been possible, in this third edition, to shorten the epistemological section; on several points I could now simply refer to the works named, which would otherwise have required detailed justification. Only the strictly necessary epistemological content has been retained. In the religious-psychological section too I was able to refer to works that threw light on the topics (“The Great Humour” 1916; “Experiences and Interpretations” 1918; “Leading Thoughts in the Nineteenth Century” 1920; together with the essay “Foreword and Postscript to my Philosophy of Religion,” printed in “Minor Works”). I have besides carried out a consolidation of the two groupings of religious-psychological types, determined by different points of view, between which I earlier thought it possible to distinguish. Of the notes, a number have been omitted as outdated or superfluous. Where it was necessary, I have added new notes.

The book’s fundamental thought has remained the same. Its significance has confirmed itself to me over the years by what I have experienced or learned. Often it is precisely objections that have led to fresh corroboration. The book’s fundamental thought is not a key that unlocks everywhere, but it leads one to pose fruitful questions and to enter upon investigations that one would otherwise be inclined to think superfluous. It warns against dogmatism of every kind, and it points at the same time to a deep-lying human need that can hardly die out so long as the life of the spirit is not being extinguished. It does not solve the great problem it treats, but it can lead to ever-renewed reflection. And I hope that the book will continue to work in the direction here indicated.

Carlsberg, 28 February 1924.

HARALD HØFFDING.

Chapter 1

Problem and Procedure

Οὐκ ἔστι λύειν ἀγνοοῦντα τὸ δεσμόν.

ARISTOTLE.

(One cannot loose a knot without knowing where the binding lies).

1. By *philosophy of religion* one could mean either a thinking that springs from religion and builds on religion, or a thinking that takes religion as its object. It is in this latter sense that the term shall be taken here. The thinking that springs from and builds on religion itself belongs to the subject matter of the philosophy of religion and should not be called philosophy of religion.

By religion we think first of all of a state of mind in which feeling and need, fear and hope, enthusiasm and devotion play a larger role than reflection and inquiry, and in which intuition and image hold more sway than investigation and reasoning. To be sure, again and again in the religious life there will arise an involuntary need to give an account of one's condition and of its content—of the worth of one's motives and the validity of one's thoughts. But the religious thinking that thus arises does not pose the religious problem in a decisive way. Its problems arise within religion, but religion itself does not become a problem. No other starting point is yet recognized than religion itself; in any case other starting points are so subordinate in relation to religion that they do not acquire decisive significance. Of this kind is religious thinking in those times in which religion is everything on the spiritual plane. These are the classical times of religion: partly the great times of origins, in which religion with all the power of originality draws all strength and interest to itself; partly the great times of organization, in which all existing culture is shaped or bent into obedience under the highest religious ideas. In such classical times there is a great unity, or at least a great harmony, in the domain of

spiritual life; the division of labour that sets in at a certain stage of cultural development has not yet made itself felt in this domain. Christianity had such a classical time in the age of the primitive Christian community, and later in the great organizational period at the height of the Middle Ages. A religious problem forms only when other sides of spiritual life—science and art, morality and social life—begin to free themselves and to appear with the claim of having independent value. They then judge religion from their points of view and by their standards, whereas religion in its classical times either simply ignored them—as in the times of origins—or—as in the times of organization—valued them from its own point of view and by its own standard, so that the question became whether these two different evaluations could be brought into mutual harmony.—There must be definite historical conditions present before the religious problem can be posed in a decisive way. It is, if one will, only in unhappy times that a religious problem exists. For this problem is the expression of a spiritual disharmony: the different elements of spiritual life no longer work together in so unified a way as before; they lead in different directions, among which one must perhaps ultimately choose. But then both the necessity and the possibility of an investigation are also present.

That religion is made into a problem will be offensive to many. But thought must have the right to investigate everything, once it has awakened, and only thought itself can mark out its boundaries. Who else should mark out its boundaries? He who perceives no problem has of course no reason to think; but neither has he any reason to prevent others from thinking. He who fears losing his spiritual support must keep away. No one wishes to rob the poor man of his only lamb—but then the poor man must not unnecessarily come dragging it along the highway and demand that traffic be stopped on his account. Experience shows, moreover, that it is rather the oxen than the lambs that loudly announce themselves with their indignation in season and out of season (especially out of season). It is not so much the genuinely poor in spirit as the stiff and blustering dogmatists who take offense when free inquiry claims the right to stir on the religious plane as on any other.

The investigation I wish to undertake here addresses itself neither to those who are finished nor to those who are fearful. The finished are found in every camp, not least among the so-called “freethinkers”—a class of people who, like the “Worms” in Linnaeus’s system, can be characterized only by negative predicates, because the class is supposed to encompass so many different forms. The finished are in possession of a definite negative or positive solution to the religious problem and have thereby lost the sense for further thinking about it. The fearful dare not think about it.—Rather, the

investigation addresses itself to those who are *becoming*. “One who is becoming will always be grateful”—no matter in which direction his becoming goes.

Philosophy is, as is well known, richer in ideas, perspectives, and discussions than in definitive results, and the philosopher would often be in a sorry state if he did not believe that the constant striving after truth belongs to the highest spiritual values, which it is the task of all true religion to uphold. Even if we could learn nothing else from a philosophy-of-religion investigation, we could perhaps learn something about the causes of the strife that rages over religious questions, and about this strife’s significance for the development of spiritual life. And should the religious problem prove insoluble, we might perhaps learn why it is insoluble.

2. The philosophy of religion should not proceed from a finished philosophical system. In a certain sense all thinking must be systematic, for “system” literally means “that which stands together,” and it is an inexorable demand placed on our thoughts that they must be able to “stand together” with one another. There is an inner coherence and consistency which in every domain is the ultimate mark of truth, and which must therefore also be required in the domain of the philosophy of religion. But the philosophy-of-religion enterprise will be most fruitful where religion and its phenomena are not placed in relation to some completed philosophical conception or other, but are illuminated by a philosophizing that is itself in the process of investigating whether a completion is possible at all. The task is to discuss religion’s relation to spiritual life. Religion is itself a kind of or form of spiritual life, and it is judged rightly only when seen in its relation to other kinds or forms. It is no alien standard that is thereby applied to religion. For there is a service from which no spiritual power—even if it appears under the greatest names—can exempt itself, namely to serve the deep and rich development of spiritual life. The philosophy-of-religion task will therefore above all be to find the means for investigating whether religion, under the conditions of our spiritual culture, can continue to render such service. In solving, or better: in treating this task, the philosophy of religion cannot come equipped with other presuppositions than those which every other science brings to the treatment of its subject. Very often it will surely be compelled to declare that there are questions that cannot be answered, because the conditions in the spiritual domain are more complex and more diverse than positive and negative dogmatists suppose. Yet it is not without significance that the problems are discussed. The conscious insight into the impossibility of a solution (*docta ignorantia*) naturally invites one to investigate whether it is then so absolutely necessary that a solution be found. In addition, one’s eye will be sharpened for the particular conditions under which

our spiritual culture lives, and above all for the significance of the division of labour in the spiritual domain, through which the religious problem becomes a special form of the general problem of culture.

A philosophy-of-religion investigation can suitably be arranged so as to consist of an epistemological, a psychological, and an ethical part.

In its classical times, religion satisfies all of humankind's spiritual needs, including its drive for knowledge. Religious ideas then contain for human beings the explanation of existence in its entirety and in its individual parts. But when an independent science has developed, another kind of understanding or explanation appears alongside the religious one, and the question becomes whether these two kinds are compatible. Many hold that the relation is this, that the new, scientific mode of explanation increasingly replaces the religious explanation where particulars are concerned, but that it cannot be applied to existence considered as a whole—to what one customarily calls the “first” or the “last” questions. Then one must discuss whether religion is able to solve the riddles that science cannot solve. If it should then turn out that religious conceptions, whether with respect to the whole or to the particular, cannot help with anything that could rightly be called understanding or explanation, then one must raise the question what significance these conceptions can still have.

This last question leads from the epistemological philosophy of religion to the psychological. For if religious conceptions no longer have cognitive value, the value they might possess must consist in being expressions of sides of the life of the soul other than the intellectual. An attempt must then be made to describe the religious life of the soul, especially the relation of conceptions to religious experience and religious feeling. Through this it will become apparent that religion in its innermost nature has to do not with the understanding of existence but with the *evaluation* of it, and that religious conceptions express the relation in which factual existence, as we know it, stands to that which for us gives life its highest value. The core of religion is—according to the hypothesis to which we are led—a faith in the persistence of value in existence. This faith appears in great, vivid images in the popular religions, especially in the highest among them. Even in those who stand outside every popular religion, such a faith may stir, even though it does not here take definite shape.

The transition from psychological to ethical philosophy of religion is naturally motivated by the question: what ethical value does it have that one believes in the persistence of value? Ethics concerns the production of values, and the possibility cannot be dismissed that the work of producing values leaves no time and no strength for living

in the thought of their persistence. The ethical philosophy of religion forms a parallel to the epistemological. In its classical times, religion directly and indirectly determines the evaluation of all actions and all conditions of life. The religious problem arises on this point when an independent ethics has developed that seeks, by its own path, the grounding and motivation for the evaluation of human actions. And on this point the problem is posed in the sharpest and most pressing way, for the ultimate standard for judging religion must belong to the ethical domain, where the final reckoning of the spiritual account takes place.—

Within the framework here indicated, we shall be able to find room for all essential aspects of the religious problem. I wish to treat this problem not only with the intellectual interest that is aroused by a great and comprehensive subject, but also in the mood that comes from the consciousness of standing before a spiritual form of life in which the human race through millennia has deposited some of its deepest and most inward experiences.

3. Before we enter upon the individual parts of the philosophy of religion, it will be useful to give a somewhat more detailed characterization of the content of the religious problem.

In the Protestant world it is fairly generally acknowledged that one must distinguish between knowledge and faith. The Catholic Church does not acknowledge this distinction in its full extent and therefore does not acknowledge any religious problem in the intellectual domain. It maintains that God's existence can be proved by the paths that Thomas Aquinas, supported by Aristotle, pointed out, and it has even declared it a matter of faith to accept that these proofs suffice. The tradition from the great time of the Middle Ages, when "one did not doubt and was therefore nearer to the truth" (to use a sentence from one of Thomas Aquinas's modern biographers), is continually upheld, and it is not acknowledged that a disharmony has really entered into spiritual life. The distinction between knowledge and faith concedes that such a disharmony is present—that the unity of spiritual life is broken. Is this distinction itself then only a station on the way, in that development will lead to an elimination of all religion from spiritual life, because only that can endure which can enter into a harmonious relation with the other elements of life?—Whether one now assumes that it is only the classical time of religion that is past, or that its time is altogether past, the question cannot be set aside whether spiritual value is lost in the process of dissolution that has set in, or whether a replacement can be found for the spiritual unity and self-containment that was lost. This consideration alone shows that the question of the persistence of value is an essential aspect of the religious problem,

whatever solution one inclines toward. It is not least from this side that philosophy in the last century and a half (from the time of Rousseau, Lessing, and Kant onward) has treated the religious problem. Both Romantics and Positivists have been attentive to this aspect of it.—It must of course be remembered that even if one could show that no spiritual energy was lost in the dissolution of religion, it does not follow that the energy would under the new conditions receive as valuable an application as in the classical times of religion. In the spiritual domain no less than in the material, the conservation of energy is not without further ado the same as the persistence of value. Energy can persist without value persisting, while the reverse cannot well be imagined, since energy in and of itself will be a condition for the persistence and development of what is valuable. Many freethinkers proceed without further ado from the assumption that human life will become more powerful and richer when religion falls away—an assumption that is not self-evident and that rests on the presupposition that psychic equivalents are present—equivalents both in terms of value and in terms of energy. The task will then be to demonstrate these equivalents and thereby establish the persistence of value. But it is a great question and an essential aspect of the religious problem whether such equivalents can be demonstrated.—Moreover, the problem of the persistence of value will also arise within the Church, for religion and the religious life undergo constant changes; and the question becomes whether the values from the classical times of religion persist through these changes—e.g., whether primitive Christianity, both in terms of value and in terms of energy, is preserved in the Christianity of our day. In its sharpest form this problem has appeared in the assertion: “the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists.”—

But the religious problem concerns not only the persistence of value within the human world. It raises not only a psychological but also a cosmological question, namely about the relation between that which stands as the highest value for human beings and the whole of existence. Is there any connection between values and the laws and forces of existence? Are these laws and forces perhaps even ultimately determined by the highest values? Or can we perhaps not ascribe any validity to the concept of value beyond the domain of human life?

The hypothesis that will later (in the psychological philosophy of religion) be sought to be grounded holds that the proposition of the persistence of value is the actual religious axiom, which is expressed in different ways in the different religions and at the different religious standpoints. The religious problem thus concerns the question whether this axiom can really be taken to hold. And at the same time this axiom, insofar as it expresses the fundamental thought of all religion, can be used as a standard for the consistency and

significance of the individual religion or the individual religious standpoint. Finally—as already noted—the relation between ethics and religion can, with the help of this axiom, be expressed in a very simple way: how does faith in the persistence of value relate to the work of finding, producing, and preserving values?—

If the proposition of the persistence of value were to be discussed in its full scope, the discussion would become interminable, and clear starting points for conducting it would soon be lacking. I therefore emphasize at once the limits within which my investigation will move, and which must be kept in mind throughout all that follows.—When I attempt to show that the said proposition is the fundamental thought of all religion, this attempt will not have failed because it turns out that no religion expresses the proposition with clarity and consistency. It will be sufficient if an explicit need or tendency to hold fast to this fundamental thought can be demonstrated, so that the standard for the evaluation of religions in their mutual relations becomes the degree to which they are able to articulate and carry through the proposition.—When the persistence of value is spoken of, this could be understood to mean that value does not vanish, but that there is constantly value in existence, whether it decreases or increases or alternates between decrease and increase. But I understand the expression *the persistence of value* in analogy with the expression *the conservation of energy*, such that the proposition asserts a constant persistence of value through all changes of form. It will perhaps be necessary here to distinguish between potential and actual value, just as one distinguishes between potential and actual energy, and the one distinction is just as clear and just as justified as the other.—But the persistence of value through all changes of form and despite the difference between possibility and actuality is nonetheless only a minimum. It may be maintained that the mere persistence of value is not satisfying and actually contains a contradiction, since value can persist only by growing, since mere repetition dulls, while on the other hand change is valuable only when it brings enhancement. That an increase of value does not conflict with the conservation of energy needs no further demonstration; the increase of value presupposes only a new and more perfect application of energy, not an increase of energy as a whole. It is for the sake of simplicity that I limit the investigation to the persistence of value. And it will also turn out that religious consciousness has at bottom limited itself to this as well. The persistence of value will present us with difficulties and tasks enough, even if we do not enter into everything that lies in the unavoidable consequence that value can persist only if it increases. Yet we must not forget that this consequence is present.—Finally, when the persistence of value is under discussion, one might ask: which value and how much value? I enter into these questions only insofar

as the difference between the different religions and religious standpoints essentially depends on the different answers they give to them. It is clear that the proposition of the persistence of value can be accepted whatever answers one gives. The hypothesis that the persistence of value is the fundamental religious proposition is not shaken by the fact that the different religions and religious standpoints diverge greatly from one another with respect to the character and extent of the valuable in whose persistence they believe.

Value is the property of something that it brings about a real satisfaction or can become the means to such. Value can therefore be immediate or mediate. Immediate value we seek to hold fast when it is given, and to produce when it is not given. We thus make it our end. That we make something an end presupposes, conversely, that we have an experience or a supposition of its immediate value. Mediate value belongs to that which serves the attainment of an end—that is, of an immediate value. Mediate value need not be potential value. For what serves as a means for attaining something of immediate value itself acquires value in our eyes, even though its value stands as derived. There are all possible transitions between mediate and immediate value, and through the shifting of motives the former passes over into the latter, so that what at first had value only as a means now acquires value as an end. Potential value, on the other hand, often means only the possibility that something will acquire value as a means—that is, the possibility of mediate value.—Which values are experienced and therefore acknowledged at the different standpoints will depend on the different character of those standpoints. It is a being's nature that determines its need, and it is its need that determines what acquires value for it. The religious axiom thus shows the necessity of a religion's character being determined by the nature and need of the human beings who profess it. For one cannot seriously believe in the persistence of values that one does not know at least approximately from one's own experience.—

Every application of the concept of value presupposes a relation to a whole whose persistence and development require definite conditions. Such wholes are organisms, personalities, societies, and finally the human race. In an individual whole endowed with consciousness (a personality), feelings of pleasure and displeasure, in all their various degrees and forms, appear as symptoms of a need to maintain or to call forth the conditions of the whole's persistence. Here, then, value is known by immediate experience. But by way of analogy the concept of value—and with it the concept of wholeness, which makes rational discussion of values possible—can be applied to all wholes.—A fuller demonstration than can be given here of the significant connection

between the concepts of value and wholeness I have attempted in *Den menneskelige Tanke* (pp. 238–241; 346–349) and in *Totalitet som Kategori*, ch. 5.

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Chapter 2

Epistemological Philosophy of Religion

2.1 Understanding

Ihm ziemt's die Welt im Innern zu bewegen.

GOETHE.

(It befits him to move the world from within.)

4. Against the supposition I have put forward, that the core of religion is faith in the persistence of value, it might seem to tell that theoretical motives have after all played, and still for many play, a considerable role in the development of religious ideas. I have moreover already remarked that since religion in its classical times is everything for the human being, it in such times also satisfies its drive for knowledge—that is, provides it with means for and forms of understanding and explanation of existence. In the classical times of religion there exists no independent drive for knowledge, any more than special means and forms for satisfying such a drive. The distinction between knowledge and faith, between understanding and evaluation, comes forward only in the critical times—that is, in the times when religion has become a problem. This distinction began to make its way only after a number of violent collisions between religion and science. Only reluctantly has one begun, from the religious side, to learn that it is not religion's business to give us a scientific understanding of the world. What all theologians now repeat, that the Bible is not to teach us natural science, no one would hear when Bruno, Galileo, and Spinoza said it. The persecution of heretics ran its course, and only afterwards did one see the rightness of what the heretics had said. In other domains the same conflict

repeats itself; in our days it is the humanities whose independence is at stake.

Every great religion appears in history with a world-view, in that it gathers up within itself, in a distinctive manner, the whole circle of ideas of its time. Christianity, for example, stood in the first centuries as attractive to many by its intellectual content as well. TATIAN thus went over to Christianity because this “philosophy of the barbarians,” as he called it, seemed to him to explain what he had not before understood: “the coming-to-be of the world.” The old apologists stood generally at the standpoint that Christianity contained the best solution to the riddles of thought. When Plato and other Greek philosophers seemed to hint at similar solutions, this was to be explained, according to Justin Martyr, either by their having been influenced by the Israelite prophets, or else by the fact that “the Word” (Logos), before it became flesh, had worked illuminatingly within human beings. In comparison with the earlier religions, Christianity had—as is generally the case with the higher religions in relation to the lower—a certain rational character, and above all a simplicity, a plain grandeur, which could not but work attractively on many who knew only the earlier religions with their motley mythologies. In so far as the world-view given in the biblical writings was not detailed enough, the Church Fathers and the Schoolmen supplemented it by the aid of Greek science.

Just as Christianity does for the western portion of humanity, so Buddhism stands for the eastern portion not merely as a great religion, but as a great world-view, whose ideas have a certain rational character and cannot be understood without acquaintance with the antecedent Indian thought.

When the opposition between religious and scientific understanding of existence is spoken of, the weight is as a rule laid on the fact that science—especially in the domains of astronomy, geology, and biology—has led to results that conflict with religion’s transmitted teachings. A great part of the work of the modern apologists accordingly goes to showing the compatibility of the transmitted religious ideas with those scientific results that really stand firm. Towards modern natural science one applies, with greater or lesser success—and with greater or lesser taste—the same process of accommodation that the apologists of antiquity applied towards Greek science. But for the illumination of the religious problem as a whole, this entire discussion for and against is of slight interest, except perhaps in so far as it furnishes characteristic examples of the accommodation which the life of religious ideas—like everything living—undergoes, or strives to undergo, in the face of new conditions of life. What is the main matter, on the contrary, is that it is two wholly different kinds or types of “understanding” that here stand over against one another. They are two ways of thinking and of explaining events—two ways so

different that once one has begun with the one, one will not be able to find any point at which it is justified and possible to go over to the other. The whole mental condition is so heterogeneous that the word “understanding” is in reality used here in two wholly different senses. Let me take a single example. A sudden storm and tidal flood, which brings about the destruction of many fishermen at sea, is explained in natural-scientific fashion by the states of the air and the sea in the preceding days. But in the funeral oration over the drowned, the “understanding” of what has happened is found in this, that God wished to give the survivors a sign, that they should be converted.¹ At what point in the series of natural causes can one now suppose that this divine intervention has taken place? The natural causes form a connected series, from which no link can be taken out. A choice must be made between the two “understandings.” The one kind of understanding aims, so far as possible, to form connected series of links, each of which can be pointed out in experience. The more the state of the air and the sea at the moment of the catastrophe has been brought into connected sequence with their states in the preceding days, the better—according to the one type of understanding—one is said to understand the catastrophe. According to the other type, it is understood by the value it acquires through its influence on the minds of those who suffer under it, and this value is regarded as intended—as the purpose of a divine intervention.

The scientific type of understanding has developed in a clear and fruitful manner especially in the course of the last three centuries. It does not exclude a religious evaluation, but it excludes a confusion of this evaluation with explanation proper. It is the task of philosophical epistemology to investigate the presuppositions and the forms of thought that lie at the foundation of scientific knowledge, and it will be of philosophy-of-religion interest to bring out these presuppositions and forms of thought and to compare them with the foundation of religious “understanding.” Through this we shall be able to obtain information as to how far religion will still be able to have significance for the satisfaction of our drive for knowledge.

2.1.1 Causal Explanation

5. When one sets up the proposition that every event has its cause—the so-called causal principle—one thereby establishes the principle that existence is intelligible. This proposition can never become more than a hypothesis, since we can never understand everything, never point out causes for all events. But it contains the presupposition with which we involuntarily meet events that awaken our attention; at any rate it is the presupposition that brings us to look about for earlier events when an event has

occurred.

We can here disregard entirely the question of the causal principle's justification and origin, since the mutually divergent conceptions here offered need not acquire any philosophy-of-religion significance. Whether the acknowledgement of this proposition is due to habit or to an inner necessity in our nature, the need to find causes stirs more or less in everyone, and the religious conception bears witness to it as well as the scientific. Indeed, religious ideas have a peculiar epistemological interest precisely in this, that they testify how deeply the need to find causes lies in human nature, since it expresses itself even there where no independent scientific interest has yet arisen. The opposition between religion and science comes forward only when regard is had to the *character* of the causes one acknowledges as right, real causes (*veræ causæ*). *Both religious and scientific understanding are a leading back of the unknown to the known; the difference between them rests on what this known is.*

Scientific understanding requires that the cause of an event be demonstrated in events that themselves establish themselves in experience just as well as the event to be explained. The task here becomes to interpret the series of events by finding as many individual links in this series, and as close a connection between them, as possible. The aim is to interpret nature by nature itself, just as one interprets a passage in a book by comparing it with other passages in the same book. Religious understanding does not make the demand that the cause should stand in continuous connection with the effect and itself be demonstrated as an experience just as well as the event to be explained. It does not investigate its causes in the critical manner that science does. It does not explain nature by nature itself, but by something that is different from or stands outside nature, that "pushes in from without." Thus, at any rate, religious understanding most frequently appears in history. In contrast to this religious understanding, the special form that empirical science—in both the mental and the material domains—gives to the causal principle can be designated as *the principle of natural causes*. If it cannot be applied, we understand nothing, when it is the scientific type of understanding and the corresponding intellectual habit that prevail in us.

Only the principle of natural causes satisfies the need for a special explanation of the particular, determinate event. Galileo thus showed that in the debate between the different contending astronomical hypotheses it could be of no use to appeal to God's intervention, since for God's omnipotence it is just as easy to let the sun move round the earth as to let the earth move round the sun. This cause therefore cannot help us to a choice between the hypotheses. It is a key that unlocks everywhere; but it is not such a

master key that science seeks; science's interest is to investigate the peculiar character of the different locks, and it therefore demands a key of its own for every lock. If a master key were sufficient, the difference of the locks would become meaningless—and would contain an unsolved problem!—To appeal to God's will gives no scientific understanding, but is—scientifically regarded—an admission that one does not understand the event.

The deepest justification for the principle of natural causes I find in a need for continuity, which lies in the nature of our consciousness and which already shows itself in the general need to find causes. Our consciousness strives involuntarily to gather up and hold together its elements and to preserve unity with itself, even when it stands before a new content. This new content it then strives to shape, alter, and arrange, so that the new shows itself to be a new form of something old. Self-recognition then becomes possible in spite of the shifting of content, and the unity of the personal life mirrors itself in the continuity thereby brought about. The work of knowledge is here closely bound up with the work on the development of character. We speak of a character—in the pronounced sense—only where unity and continuity prevail in the whole striving, and where there is not again and again a leaping over to something new. In analogy with this, knowledge seeks to find as much unity and continuity as possible, to exhibit the new as a transformation or continuation of the old; and only where this succeeds is a full appropriation and understanding won. The principle of natural causes, which leads one to build series as long and as continuous as possible, is therefore no accident, but is closely bound up with the very nature of personality. It is therefore incorrect when personality and science are set in sharp opposition to one another. Scientific work is a work of personality. And the more this work succeeds, the more does causal explanation approach grounding and recognition. The differences in existence are reduced to the least possible when we survey, at a single glance, “under the form of eternity,” great regions of existence.

Religious understanding too—in the mythical and dogmatic forms in which it most frequently appears in history—leads the unknown back to the known. But this known is here as a rule the will of one or more personal beings. The religious consciousness supposes itself to know what the divine will aims at, and recognizes in events the expression of this will. Its interest is not to find an inner connection among events themselves, but to see all events (in the whole of nature, or in some single domain) as the expression of one and the same power. It places itself at the centre, or supposes itself to be at the centre, and from there it surveys the whole circle of existence.

The difficulty for the religious conception here becomes this, that the radius with

which this circle is described is not known. From one and the same centre many different circles can be described. Therefore every “central” consideration (as it has moreover been attempted not only on religious presuppositions, but also in speculative philosophical form) will be powerless with respect to the understanding of the special events. A theological or speculative epistemology will therefore not be able to be carried through. There do not even exist serious attempts at one; but we must hold to the epistemology that empirical and critical philosophy has developed on the basis of the history of empirical science.

6. When the scientific type of understanding has begun to prevail, but is excluded at certain selected points where religious understanding still claims dominion, there arises the bastard concept called wonder, *miracle*. The miracle presupposes that both types make themselves felt, but that there is a leap over from the one type to the other. Where either a certain degree of scientific understanding or of knowledge is not present, the miracle can only mean a deviation from the accustomed. The natural man wonders when the hitherto unseen or unheard-of happens. But the miracle proper presupposes a certain knowledge of natural laws—a continuity that is broken—a rule from which an exception is made. Miracles must therefore occur according to the law of parsimony; if they come so frequently that they become the rule, they form a continuous connection, and the concept of miracle is abolished.

If one does not set up the principle of natural causes in a wholly dogmatic manner, one cannot maintain in advance the impossibility of miracles. But the decisive thing is here again the way the problem is posed and the intellectual habit. For him who asks and sets up his problems according to the scientific type, for him a miracle can never come to be. He may come to stand before something he cannot explain, since no cause (in the sense in which he speaks of cause) can be found, or at any rate has hitherto been found. But he can never discover that there is no natural cause. The religious consciousness itself cannot—without ascribing omniscience to itself—maintain that an event *cannot* be explained according to natural laws. To know that something falls outside the laws of nature, one must know them all and know all possible special applications of them. Only by a revelation could one come to know that in the particular case a miracle is present. It is not the miracle that confirms the revelation, but the revelation that decides what is a miracle. And since a revelation is itself a miracle, one can only by a miracle come to know whether a miracle has happened.—It is consistent when the Catholic Church, which decides what is revelation, also demands to decide what is a miracle and what is not. Nothing may be taken for a miracle unless it is sanctioned as such by “apostolic and

ordained authority.”²

In the case of miracles of which one is not oneself an eyewitness, the question will particularly be whether the report is so securely transmitted, and whether the eyewitness has been so keen an observer, that one will sooner be able to assume a deviation from the laws of nature than an error in transmission and observation. A report that does not derive from an observer who has sufficient acquaintance with the natural conditions and natural laws in question has no scientific significance.

7. The preceding consideration rested on the scientific concept of cause, according to which an event is understood by being seen in its inner connection with other events, as a continuation of them or as a transformation into new form of their content. The presupposition of all such causal explanation is a principle of unity that makes connection possible. We reach this principle by analysis of the very concept of causal connection or reciprocal action. It is the bond that holds existence together and makes it a whole, more than a chaos of elements—even if it is a whole we cannot survey.

The principle of unity at which we have thus arrived recalls the concept of God. But the customary line of thought often reaches its concept of God by another road: not by going back to the presupposition of the causal series, to the principle that makes such a series possible at all, but by continuing the causal series backwards to a “first cause.” By virtue of this line of thought one will say, in the face of the preceding development: “Religion gladly leaves it to science—a few supernatural events excepted—to find the finite causes and to spin out the causal series as far as possible. The causes that science can find are nevertheless always subordinate, derived causes (*causæ secundæ*). What religion maintains is that existence becomes meaningless if we do not at last find the origin of the whole causal series in a first cause, an absolute cause, in which thought finds rest—where all further questioning falls away—and from which the full, clear light streams out over everything.”

This line of thought stems from ARISTOTLE and is taken up by THOMAS AQUINAS, on whose authority it is still espoused by Catholic theology,³ as well as by many Protestant theologians. It is the so-called cosmological proof of God’s existence—the most important of all “proofs”—that we here stand before.

That the series of causes must be limited is inferred from the consideration that otherwise no complete explanation of any link whatever in the series of events would have been reached. “If there is no first,” says ARISTOTLE, “there is no cause at all.” It is thus the condition of existence’s intelligibility that one here supposes oneself to be relying on. It is a rationalistic tendency that lies at the foundation of this theological

line of thought. Existence must be comprehensible!—that is the underlying postulate. Aristotle does not, however, assume that the first cause began to work at a definite point of time, so that “the world” has a beginning. And Thomas also concedes that it is only by the way of faith that one comes to assume that the world has a beginning (*mundum incepisse, sola fide tenetur*).

KANT has subjected this proof to a criticism that leads him to the result that it rests on “a false self-satisfaction of human reason.” In the main his criticism stands in force to this very day. In what follows I make use in part of his objections, adding to them some other misgivings.

Even if we could build a connected causal series, at what point should we then break off our search for finite causes in order to hang the whole chain on a “first cause”—as Zeus in Homer threatens to hang the whole world on a peak of Mount Olympus? What mark can we have that we are at the “next to first” cause, so that we must now set about making the decisive leap?—And why should the causal series not be able to be infinite? That an infinite series is unthinkable is a dogmatic assertion. There can be series which, by virtue of the law that holds for the relation between their links, can always be continued. Such series we think—not by running through all the links, which is of course impossible—but by thinking the law of their connection. Such a series is the causal series. It is built by virtue of the causal principle, which says that everything that happens has its cause. This proposition must—if it is accepted at all—also be accepted as holding for every single link in the series, for the “first” one has gone back to as well as for all the others. The assumption of an absolutely first cause would thus conflict with the causal principle—although it was precisely to be justified by existence’s absolute intelligibility, and so by the causal principle!—

Popular theology will especially hold to the form of the cosmological proof that runs thus: “Since everything has its cause, the world too must have its cause.” One operates here with the concept “world” without noticing that it contains the same or similar difficulties as those that just showed themselves in the concept of God. If by “world” one understands the sum total of all that exists, or at any rate of all “finite” existing things, then it is a concept that can never be completed. The given is never completed; new experiences are always coming in, which make new conceptual determinations necessary. We therefore never come, by the road of scientific inquiry, to a point at which there could be a question of a cause of “the whole world.” The given constitutes a whole, which we analyse in order to find its laws and its elements; but every given whole points over to other wholes; we seek to work all given wholes together into a still higher whole;

but however far this work be continued, the same task will always present itself anew. There is here a series of like kind with the causal series—a series that by virtue of its own law cannot be completed. The concept “world” is therefore properly a false concept, though one operates with it so briskly, plays with it as with a ball.

2.1.2 The World of Space

8. When the religious consciousness historically shows a tendency to limit the series of causes, this is in part to be explained by the need for intuitive vividness. The religious consciousness wants a vivid image of its object, and such an image presupposes limitation. With this in turn hangs together its tendency to refer the divine to definite places in space. Spatial ideas are our clearest ideas, and what we wish to represent clearly we therefore seek to shape into spatial images or schemata. With this there naturally combines the idea that everything that exists must belong at a definite place in the world, must be localized. What is not at some definite place seems, to the childlike conception, which is decidedly realistic, not to be at all. Just as, with respect to the explanation of the world, it would be the simplest thing if we could come upon the deity by following the series of causes link by link, so also, with respect to the conception of the world, it would be the simplest thing if the human being needed only to lift his eyes upward to find the deity, or at any rate could behold its dwelling.

Antiquity's conception of the world met this need. For it the world was limited. The earth stood at the world's centre, and the vault of heaven, which was not thought to be extraordinarily far off, formed the world's outermost boundary. The bright sky has, especially for the Indo-Germanic peoples, been regarded as deity or as the seat of the deity. The stem from which many of the Indo-Germanic languages form their word for “God” properly denotes sky or heavenly. Thus the Indian *devas*, the Persian *deva*, the Greek Ζεύς (Δίος), the Latin *deus*, and so on. Herodotus says of the Persians that they call the sky Zeus, and with this agrees the fact that the natural background of the god Ahura Mazda (Ormuzd) is assumed by the more recent history of religion to be the sky. The Greeks supposed, indeed, in the oldest time, that the gods dwelt more particularly on Mount Olympus, but later thought of the sky or “the aether” as their dwelling. Aristotle says: “All human beings assume that there are gods, and all, both barbarians and Hellenes, assign to the deity the uppermost place.” The opposition between heaven and earth thus became quite naturally, for antiquity, one with the opposition between the divine and the human, between the eternal and the changeable, between the perfect and the imperfect. The expressions “the higher” and “the lower” had originally a literal meaning;

the symbolic meaning is here, as everywhere, the later one. Aristotle's incorporation of antiquity's astronomical conception into his system became of decisive importance. Since both this conception and his whole system seemed to be compatible with the biblical circle of ideas, and capable of serving for the further working-out of it, they were taken up by ecclesiastical theology and through it became dominant right into the modern age.

Among the Jewish people too we meet with the great religious significance of the opposition between heaven and earth. In the opinion of some, Jahveh was originally a thunder-god; at any rate he reveals himself with special majesty in the heavenly phenomena. Heaven is his seat, and the earth his footstool. The New Testament conception stands here entirely on the ground of the Old. There is sometimes talk of several heavens (2 Corinthians XII, 2; Ephesians IV, 10), and God's dwelling is then the heavenly holy of holies, which is above all the heavens. Accounts such as that of Jesus's visible ascension and of Paul's rapture to the third heaven testify that the ancient picture of the world is presupposed. As these accounts stand, they are plainly to be taken literally, though the more recent theology (even the orthodox) is on this point inclined to apply the rationalistic explanation.

There was both vividness and security in the narrow frame within which the picture of the world thus presented itself. Without being disturbed and disquieted by infinite distances, the religious consciousness could give itself wholly to the great experiences of life and regard the all-decisive process of redemption—resolved on in heaven and accomplished on earth—as that about which the whole outer life of the world also turned. There was as it were a ladder between heaven and earth; the two worlds, the world of the highest value and the world of contending values, stood in vivid reciprocal action. Poets like Homer and Dante are testimony to what foothold and what support the limited picture of the world afforded the human imagination.

But within the religious consciousness itself there shows itself, at a somewhat higher stage of development, an opposite tendency, which at the cost of vividness aims at abolishing the localization of the content of religious ideas. It came to appear an imperfection that the deity should really have its dwelling at a definite place, so that it must either move through space in order to come to the human being, or the human being must travel long roads to meet his God. God must be omnipresent and all-embracing if he is not to be limited and imperfect, as a human being is. However short the distance between heaven and earth was thought to be, it nevertheless became too long for the religious need. The deity had to stand in a far more intimate relation to the human being

than localization at definite places made possible.

In the biblical writings and among the ecclesiastical theologians we find, then, a double current. Vividness is held fast; but where it is the inwardness of feeling, rather than the imagination's need for intuition, that leads the word, there the significance of the spatial relation is abolished. God dwells in heaven—but he is truly not far from us, for in him we are and live and move. Jesus ascends to heaven and shall come thence again—but he lives in believers and is with them all their days.

The religious conception has here, in its classical times, a *Both—And*, which later is gradually replaced by an *Either—Or*.

9. What made it possible for the theologians of earlier times to hold fast to this Both—And was the bold use they made of allegorical or symbolic interpretation. An allegorical interpretation did not, according to their conception, exclude the literal meaning. The relation between the two remained in a certain indeterminacy, which not seldom could lead to violent collisions. "There was lacking," says ADOLF HARNACK in his history of dogma, "a definite rule for how far the letter of Holy Scripture should hold. Has God human shape, has he eyes, has he a voice, does Paradise lie on the earth, do the dead rise with all their limbs, with hair too, and so on?—to all these questions and a hundred like them no certain answer was given, and therefore there was strife between the adherents of one and the same confession. Allegorize all had to, but all had on the other hand also to take certain passages of Scripture literally. But what a difference there was between an Epiphanius and a Gregory of Nyssa, and how many nuances there were between the crude anthropomorphists and the spiritualists! These last for the most part feared the arguments of the former, often also their fists, and they had to be anxious about their own orthodoxy."⁴

AUGUSTINE is certainly the one who has contributed most to displacing the merely literal conception. His Platonic studies have here had decisive influence and have—in conjunction with his profound and strongly agitated inner life—led him to a clearer view of the difference between the spiritual and the material, and thereby led him to utter thoughts in which he stands as the precursor of Descartes and Kant. What in this connection especially interests us is his rejection of all spatial determinations as invalid for the divine. Where he speaks of his own earlier conception, he says: "I did not know that God is a spirit that has no limbs with length and breadth, any more than bodily mass (*moles*). The bodily (*moles*) is less in a part than in the whole, and if it is infinite, it is less in a limited part than in the infinite, and it is not everywhere as a whole (*tota ubiqve*), as God is." "God is present in his wholeness everywhere, and is yet nowhere in

place (*ubique totus, et nusquam locorum*)!” “God dwells further within my being than my own inmost self, and he is more exalted than the highest I can reach (*interior intimo meo, superior summo meo*).” “God stands above my soul, but not in the same way as heaven stands above the earth.”⁵

When thoughts such as these were appropriated and carried through, they had to lead to strife with the old picture of the world and its childlike opposition between heaven and earth. The Schoolmen of the Middle Ages held fast to the immaterial concept of God, independent of spatial determinations, and from them it passed over to the Mystics, who besides were influenced by Neoplatonic thoughts.—“Lord,” Suso’s female disciple asks him, “where is God?” The answer runs: “The masters say: God has no Where.... God is a circle whose centre is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere.”⁶ Thus, through inner contradiction, the validity of the spatial relation is abolished.

Towards accounts such as that of the visible ascension one took up in the Middle Ages this position: that one held fast that the events reported had taken place as they were described, but that they had a spiritual meaning which was the essential thing. HUGH OF ST. VICTOR explains that by “the highest” is meant the inmost in us, and that ascending to God means that we sink ourselves into ourselves and there find something that is “higher” than ourselves. But he will not therefore deny that heaven and hell are definite places in the world. His contemporary ABELARD maintains (in his remarkable “Dialogue between a Philosopher, a Jew, and a Christian”) that what is said of God in bodily form is to be understood—not, as the common man understands it, bodily and literally—but mystically and allegorically. By heaven’s exaltation above the earth is meant rather the exalted character (*sublimitas*) of the life to come than the situation of the material heaven, and that Jesus sits at God’s right hand denotes not a spatial position (*localis positio*), but equality of dignity (*æqualis dignitas*). Jesus’s ascension has indeed taken place bodily as it is reported, but it denotes nevertheless “a nobler kind of ascent” (*melior ascensus*), namely that which takes place in the souls of believers. Unlearned and simple people would not understand what is not presented in vivid form.⁷

The characteristic Both—And here comes clearly forward. It had its great advantages in a pedagogical respect, since one did not need to make any sharp distinction between idea and reality, symbol and truth. With his bodily eyes the human being could look up to heaven, the seat of power and grace, but the same heaven he had in the inner states in which the divine made known its authority and bestowed its consolation. The evangelical narratives could be taken according to the letter and yet at the same time be interpreted spiritually and edifyingly. The absolute differences of place in the world of

space appeared immediately as the expression of differences of value.

10. There came, however, the time when one had to choose. There arose a conflict between an idealistic conception, which inculcates the purely spiritual significance of religious ideas, and a realistic or materialistic conception, which held to vividness and literalness. Such a conflict is known in many religions. In the *Upanishads*, the idealistic interpretation of the Vedic religion, it is said that Bráhma, the deity, is imperishable, while “name, place, time, and body” perish, wherefore none of these determinations holds for Bráhma. In Xenophanes’s and Plato’s criticism of the Greek popular faith a similar tendency shows itself. Within Mohammedanism it comes forward when, for example, the sensuous and vivid depiction of the joys of Paradise is interpreted allegorically as a presentation of spiritual enjoyments.⁸

When it began to dawn on thought that there are no absolute determinations of place, since every place is determined by its relation to other places, these again by their relation to others, and so forth, the old picture of the world was moving towards its dissolution. It went with the series of places as it went with the series of causes; one could not get the series absolutely completed, so that the picture could be bounded. And when now Copernicus showed that the simplest picture of the world was obtained by thinking of the earth as moving round the sun, so that it was no longer the world’s centre, there fell away the clear and secure frame within which the content of religious ideas had hitherto been able to be localized. It was besides soon shown—by Giordano Bruno—that it was inconsistent to hold fast to the limitation of “the world” when one accepted the relativity of all determinations of place and the Copernican astronomy. An infinite horizon opened.⁹ The difference between heaven and earth fell away, and an Either—Or had to replace the earlier Both—And: only the idealistic meaning of the word “heaven” was now tenable, if this word was to express a religious idea.

To this there now came also another movement of thought. Just as one had hitherto found spiritual differences of value expressed in a vivid way by spatial distances, so one had generally made no sharp difference between the spiritual and the material. With the beginning of natural science this difference came forward more clearly, and it came—with Kepler and Descartes—to stand as a chief mark of the material that it is extended in space. It had now to become a special problem, not merely how the spiritual and the material stand related to one another, but also whether the spiritual world is as comprehensive as the material world, according to the new picture of the world, showed itself to be. The security with which one had hitherto been able to find spiritual things expressed in material forms was quite particularly shaken by this. Formerly one had

been able literally to see “spirits”; after the Cartesian reform of psychology this was no longer possible. The spiritual world came to stand in opposition to the world of space, of extension, and of vividness, however one might think of the inner relation between them. Everything vivid could now at last, that is to say, from a religious point of view, acquire only symbolic significance.

But it was easier for philosophy than for theology to draw this consequence. With thinkers like Bruno and Spinoza the religious ideas underwent an inwardization and an infinitization that corresponded to the new conception of the world and carried further what Augustine and the Mystics had already hinted at. After long resistance and misgiving, theology began to strike into the same road. And often we now see the assertion put forward that the idealistic meaning of such expressions as “heaven” (or “hell,” and so on) is the only valid one, and the only one that the Bible and the Church have ever approved. CARDINAL NEWMAN declares, for example, that the Council of Trent does not teach that Purgatory causes sensuous pain, though he concedes that this was the Latin Church’s tradition, and that he himself has seen in the streets of Naples paintings that represented souls burning in Purgatory. But in an ecclesiastically sanctioned handbook on the doctrine of Purgatory the question is raised: “Is the flame of Purgatory really a bodily flame?” And to this it is said: “Cardinal Bellarmine answers that the general opinion of theologians is that the flame of Purgatory is a true and real flame, of the same kind as our earthly fire.” And it is added that the great majority of Church Fathers, Schoolmen, and theologians teach that Purgatory, like hell, is found at the earth’s centre, and that this doctrine is built on Holy Scripture and has always been maintained by the Church.¹⁰—Here idealism and realism stand sharply over against one another. One may by particular distinctions seek to veil the breach in spiritual development that let an Either—Or replace a Both—And (just as this had in its time replaced the immediate, childlike localization); but history will always bring it forth anew, and it is of the very greatest importance for the right understanding of the religious problem that it not be forgotten.

By the Copernican and the Cartesian reform there have been drawn more definite boundaries than could be drawn before, between thought and intuition, reality and symbolism. The philosophy-of-religion significance of this is easy to see. Of quite special significance is the expansion of the world, the infinite horizons that the material world has gained, and in relation to which the spiritual world now seems to be so limited. How will one—the question arose naturally—now be able to hold fast to the conviction that spiritual values are the highest thing in existence, that about which everything turns?

Now the outer world no longer turns about the home of the only spiritual life we know from experience!—There arose an opposition between psychology and cosmology which the past did not know. Great spirits like JACOB BÖHME and BLAISE PASCAL felt keenly the problem that lay in this, and which in religion's classical times could not be posed.—It is not, however, only for positive religion that a great, perhaps insoluble problem is here posed. For every view of life the same problem must present itself in one form or another. Naturally there are problems at all only for those who have not from indolence or anxiety given up thinking. To the problem itself we shall later return.

2.1.3 The Course of Time

11. The need for intuitive vividness makes itself felt with respect to time as well, and here too it leads to a shortening and a closing-off of the ideas. In this respect, however, we meet with one of the most significant differences that the history of religion anywhere exhibits, in that the idea of a completed course of time has no significance for so religious a people as the Indians, whereas in the faith of Zarathustra and in Christianity it is of quite decisive significance. For the Indians, time was only resultless movement, change and unrest, from which it was a matter of freeing oneself. Historical development therefore acquired no value; the abolition of temporal existence by the attainment of "Nirvana" was the highest thing. A similar trait is found in Greek thought; Plato's doctrine of ideas especially is a classical example of it: true reality is the unchangeable, that which always is what it is; the changeable phenomena of the world of experience, caught up in becoming, are at last only appearance. In the Zarathustra faith of the Iranians, on the other hand, the development of the world stands as a historical process which through a comparatively short span of time (12,000 years) reaches its conclusion, when the great struggle between good and evil—in nature, in human life, and in the world of spirits—has been carried to its end. Here the idea of a world-history in the literal sense of the word appears. All human work and all human conduct of life thereby come to stand in a mighty, cosmic illumination. The course of time, surveyable by the imagination, exercises a concentrating influence on the minds of human beings. There stands a goal before thought, towards which all striving is directed, and the human being stands as the fellow-worker of the gods. How and where this faith in the significance of history first arose is uncertain. It is not certain that it is of Indo-Germanic origin; possibly it is due to influences from the Semitic or pre-Semitic side.¹¹ It is likewise uncertain how far this faith came from the Persians to post-exilic Judaism and through this to Christianity. But the Zarathustra faith stands at any rate as the first great popular religion in which the

idea of life as historical development towards a goal determines the whole conception. The courage of human beings is strengthened in the struggle of life by the great visions of the future, by the thought of a kingdom that is to come and that is to be consummated through a judgment of the world.

In the New Testament this conception prevails in a pronounced way especially in the three first Gospels, in the Pauline epistles, and in the Revelation of John. In the Gospel of John the weight is laid with great emphasis on the point that eternal life is not merely a future but an already present life. He who believes has already passed over from death to life. The judgment, the decision, is first and foremost an inner one; the outer, future decision comes rather to stand as a concluding consequence. With respect to this idealism, which already in the present sees the ideal realized, there is indeed only a difference of degree between the various New Testament writings; but this difference of degree is of great significance; it grounds two different types of doctrine, and it is a psychological and literary-historical riddle that both the writing ("the Revelation of John") in which the consummation of "the kingdom" is most depicted as future, and the one ("the Gospel of John") in which its ideal presence is most profoundly maintained, could in tradition be ascribed to one and the same author. The opposition comes forward in the New Testament all the more strongly because the conclusion and the judgment were expected within the then living generation, whereby the tension between present and future had to be sharpened, and the living, forward-directed expectation came to form a stronger contrast to the inner possession.

In the Zarathustra faith the idealistic conception does not—presumably on account of the sober and practical character of the Iranians—come forward so clearly. But in the New Testament there appears on this point—as with respect to space—a characteristic Both—And. And here there is greater possibility that a Both—And can be maintained. For there is in itself no contradiction in the ideal's having taken root and so far being already present, and its being successively unfolded in its whole extent. The question—a question we shall later come back to—is whether such a longer successive unfolding is foreseen and taught in the New Testament. It is, according to the New Testament conception, only a short time that is to elapse before the conclusion, and it is generally a comparatively short time that lies between the creation and the judgment. The whole course of time lies between these two fixed points; in the interval the great religious events find their place, and the whole time rounds itself off into a natural whole for the imagination. There is a beginning, and there is an end, and there is no dizzying distance between them.—But when the two fixed points of support are taken away—when it is

asked what was before the “beginning” and what will be after the “end”—vividness is abolished, and there easily sets in a dizziness, just as when it dawns on consciousness that space can have no absolute boundaries.

12. It follows from the very concept of time that every moment must lie between two other moments. Thus neither a first nor a last moment can be thought. Just as the causal principle must find application to every link in the causal series, and the spatial relation hold for every place in space, so must the temporal relation too hold for every link in the temporal series. Every course of time that we represent to ourselves—the one from “the creation” to “the judgment” as well—can then only be a wave in time’s great, unsurveyable sea. A completed course of time means a period that is filled out by the realization of a certain result, a certain goal. It is the content that makes time be divided into periods. But the temporal relation spreads itself, by virtue of its own inner law, out beyond the “beginning” and the “end”; and if our thoughts can give no content, and therefore no division into periods, beyond the points of support that have hitherto stood fast for us, then we end at any rate with a question, a problem, just as with the series of causes and of determinations of place.

That the religious consciousness finds an imperfection in the temporal relation is easily intelligible. The misfortune of development in time is always more or less this, that the one period of life comes to stand as a mere means for the other. Means and end are separated, and life is divided between joyless labour and idle enjoyment. Just as little as any individual human being ought to be made a mere means for other human beings, just as little ought single moments within a human being’s life to be mere means for other moments, past and present mere means for the future. This can be avoided if the work and the development themselves acquire immediate value and can thereby themselves become the end or a part of the end. The child is then not merely a future grown human being; childhood becomes an independent period of life with its own peculiar tasks and its own distinctive value. And so must every period of life, every part of the course of time, be conceived. In this way it becomes possible “in the midst of time to live in eternity,” without falling into mystical contemplation. What is external in the differences of time thereby falls away. “Eternity” then stands not as time’s continuation or as a distant time, but as the expression of the continuity of the valuable through the changes of the times. It then becomes possible to look time’s incompleteness and infinity in the face without becoming dizzy and without receiving the impression of the restless and the purposeless. As with causal explanation and with the world of space, the only possible solution of the difficulties in the case of the temporal relation lies in the

direction of an inwardizing conception. It is the inner law and the valuable content, not the external differences, on which the weight must at last be laid. And here is something that can subsist independently of the limited frame to which the religious consciousness, in its mythical and dogmatic forms, is inclined to cling.

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2.2 Concluding Thoughts

By speculative philosophy one obtains not so much answers to the questions that common human understanding poses, as one comes to recognize that the questions themselves, being founded on concepts that have no truth, must fall away.

POUL MØLLER.

13. The final presupposition of the scientific understanding of existence is, as I have sought to show, a principle of unity that lies at the foundation of all connection in the course of time, in spatial extension, and in the causal series. Can thought now give a closer determination of, a concluding conceptual form for, this principle of unity? This question is all the more important because in the reference to a principle of unity there might seem to be a possibility of a connection between the religious and the scientific conception of existence.

We are all compelled to bring our knowledge to a close. There are points at which we in fact cannot get further. But this closing-off may be due to purely factual circumstances. The one grows tired before the other, or the one has not so many intellectual requirements as the other. The closing-off is here different for different individuals, for different ages, different peoples. It may be limitation in time and space that hinders knowledge from getting sufficient material. It is not that kind of closing-off I here ask about; I ask rather about a closing-off that does not rest on special, individual, or historical circumstances, but on the laws of thought itself.

The principle of unity is the necessary presupposition of existence's intelligibility. And since the fact that existence is within certain limits intelligible must be assumed to hang together with existence's own nature, we have a right to speak of a force or a power which brings it about that everything that exists, and everything that happens, stands in inner connection, is held together in a relation of continuity. If one defines God as the principle of existence's intelligibility, and therefore again as the principle of existence's

unity, then there seems here to be a possibility of a concept of God harmoniously compatible with scientific knowledge. In the ideas of God of the popular religions there enters—at any rate at the higher stages—this determination as a more or less prominent element. But it must be well noted that in the formation of religious concepts quite other interests than the purely theoretical and intellectual are at work. Every religious standpoint gathers up in its concept of God the highest valuable thing it knows. Ethical and aesthetic interests, but besides and above all the enthusiasm or feeling of dependence awakened during the struggle of life, drive the ideas forward to the most inward and highest concentration, which finds vent in the exclamation: God!—The religious problem arises only through a spiritual division of labour, by which in particular the intellectual interest is separated from the other interests and seeks its satisfaction by the development of special paths and forms of thought.

It is then no wonder that scientific and religious formations of concepts do not correspond to one another. The philosophical and the religious language do not stand related to one another in such a way that one could without more ado translate a thought from the one language into the other, or find, for a concept formed in the one domain, an entirely corresponding concept in the other.

Not only for the philosophical consciousness, but for the religious consciousness too, the great problem of the relation between unity and multiplicity presents itself. But while philosophical thought holds to unity as the necessary presupposition of the law-governed connection between the manifold elements, the religious consciousness in its mythical and dogmatic forms has a tendency to place unity and multiplicity in an external relation of opposition to one another, as though they were two different beings or powers. It thus forms two different concluding concepts, and it calls them: God and the world; the world is thought as a unity, in that all the multiplicity is gathered into a whole. Towards this formation of concepts philosophical thought stands in such a way that it finds one and the same difficulty in both these concepts, and therefore cannot see anything but that all that has been achieved is that the problem has been doubled; indeed there arises thereby into the bargain a third problem, in the relation of the two beings or powers to one another. If it is so, as I shall now try to show, this becomes of great importance for religious discussion. For from it follows that, because a thinker rejects the religious concept of God, one has no right to presuppose that he merely believes in what in religious language is called “the world.” The concept “world” contains philosophical difficulties similar to those the concept “God” contains, when it is to be absolutely concluding. And often it is the case that thinkers who are regarded as

atheists reject the current concept of “the world” rather than the concept of God. This holds of philosophers like Spinoza and Fichte.¹²—Polemical fanaticism naturally does not let itself be corrected, however often this state of affairs be pointed out.

If God and the world are regarded as two different beings or powers, then they must limit one another. The one ceases where the other begins. The clockmaker and the clock he has made are two different things; in a similar external relation the customary conception places God and the world. But then God cannot be an infinite being. “The world” with its laws and forces is the deity’s barrier. It is properly a polytheistic conception that arises in this way; “the world”—as different from “God”—properly becomes itself a god, and a certain personification of the world then also appears involuntarily, even within views that with great pomp proclaim themselves monotheistic.

14. The concept “world” is, as already remarked earlier, not a legitimate formation of concepts. If this concept is to denote a whole, a law-bound totality, then it is an ideal towards which inquiry steers, but which on account of the inexhaustibility of experience it will never be able completely to satisfy. Our thought is always spelling out what reality is. The mark by which a distinction can be drawn between merely subjective idea and objective reality is the law-governed connection that can be pointed out among the given phenomena. But partly there are always arising new phenomena as links in experience, and partly there show themselves to obtain, among the phenomena already given, far more complicated and mysterious relations of connection than we could at first suppose. We therefore never finish applying our criterion of reality, and the concept of reality therefore becomes an ideal concept.¹³ From the religious side one has as a rule not the patience to be content with the progressive work into which this ideal leads inquiry, namely to find ever deeper connection among ever more phenomena. One breaks off the work and regards the structure as completed. The concept “world” is therefore the expression of a half-thought. At the lowest stage of religious development this concept is not yet found. The idea of a cosmos, an ordered whole of existing things, presupposes a certain degree of thought. By a precipitate closing-off there has then been formed the pseudo-concept of an absolute whole, and after it had been introduced into religious language it has figured there ever since, as though it were a good and defensible concept.

But let us for a moment acknowledge this formation of concepts. The question then becomes that of the relation between the two beings or powers. Everywhere where there is a causal relation there must—as we have seen in what precedes—be presupposed a principle that conditions the connection between the links. If there is nothing that brings them into connection, the causal relation is unintelligible. This must hold also for

the causal relation between God and the world. But then the bond, the principle of unity, which makes their mutual relation possible, would itself be the real deity—or, if one prefers, the real world would then consist of God + “the world,” that is, of the whole that the two together form. We then come again into an incompletable series—a sign that one has been at the last thought we can really form, but has gone past it. This last valid thought is the principle of unity, the principle of conformity to law in existence. If one does not heed it, it avenges itself by reporting again—like the goblin who moves with you—every time one supposes oneself to have made an advance. There is something teasing about all limit-concepts, which comes out especially when one wants in an external manner to tie a knot in the thread of thought instead of holding to the inner connection that makes the thread a thread. Only if there could be given us from the theological side a wholly different epistemology from the one we must now work with would this teasing quality of our limit-concepts possibly be able to fall away. As it is, it follows us right up into the highest theological and metaphysical speculations. Plato already has (in the dialogue *Parmenides*) seen in this teasing quality a difficulty for his doctrine of ideas: if it is the ideas that lie at the foundation of sensible things, then there arises a new question with respect to the relation between the ideas and the things; this relation too must have its idea, and so forth. With Spinoza and Lotze the problem comes forward in the relation between substance and the individual beings (*modi*). I cannot see that theology, by its doctrine of God and the world, helps us beyond this difficulty of principle, which epistemologically is an indirect proof that we stand at a limit-concept. In the principle of unity we have a thought that is concluding *for us*, but at the same time a thought that demands ever new applications in incompletable series and series of series. One is deceived if one would find the concluding thing as a link in a series, instead of in the principle of series-formation itself.

The possibility cannot be dismissed that the incompletable of experience and of knowledge hangs together with the fact that existence itself is not finished, but is in constant development. One easily forgets that experience and knowledge themselves also belong to existence. When we speak of knowing existence, it properly means that the whole of existence is to be expressed by a single part of it or a single side of it. So long as this task is not solved, existence itself as a whole is not finished. And conversely, if existence itself is not finished, our knowledge cannot be finished either. Besides: to know the relation between the part or side of existence we call knowledge, and the rest of existence or existence as a whole, there would be needed a new knowledge—and so forth. Seen from this side too, the problem presents itself ever anew.

It is on the whole a fundamental law for all our concepts that they express relations, and that every concept presupposes a relation to other concepts. It is the inner law of all movement of thought. From this law, which may be called the law of relation, it follows that no concept can be formed of anything that does not stand in relation to something else. All movement of thought consists in pointing out likeness or difference, in finding ground or consequence, in deriving cause or effect. But likeness and difference, ground and consequence, cause and effect find application only where different links can be placed together in mutual relation.¹⁴

Every formation of a concept is a limitation, which is again abolished when thought reflects on the larger connection out of which it has taken that which is gathered up in the concept—and without which the concept's content could not be determined. The law of relation itself testifies to thought's unity, in that different terms of a relation are gathered up in one concept. But it testifies also to thought's constant limitation, since besides the terms that are gathered up in the single concept there are always presupposed other terms, whose closer determination becomes a new task. It is the nobility of our thought that it can see its own limit and at the limit always hear—by virtue of its own law—an *Excelsior!* Every concept of God, Fichte has said, is a concept of an idol. But it is precisely a spark of divinity in human thought that, in the face of all pious attempts to formulate the divine, it can recognize that they are idolatry.

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2.3 Thought and Image

*Und deines Geistes höchster Feuerflug
Hat schon am Gleichniss, hat am Bild genug.*

GOETHE.

15. We do not cease to form ideas, even when we have reached the limit of all knowledge, so that clear and contradiction-free concepts can no longer be formed. The religious need in particular will constantly lead to such formation of ideas. It will appear on closer investigation that the arising of all such ideas is due to *analogy*.

The word analogy properly denotes the same as proportion, but one is accustomed to distinguish between the uses of the two words, so that proportion indicates a quantitative likeness of relation (e.g. $1/2 = 2/4 = 3/6$, and so on), while analogy denotes a qualitative likeness of relation (e.g. red stands to orange as orange to yellow). By the help of

proportion we can discover unknown magnitudes, if only we know that they are terms in a proportion whose other terms are known to us. Analogy, on the other hand, is a highly imperfect aid to our knowledge. It cannot give us any positive knowledge of the unknown terms, but serves especially to express the relation between terms we know beforehand. It moreover passes easily from being a conceptual relation over to being a poetic juxtaposition, and it moves generally on the boundary between thought and poetry.¹⁵

In my work *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* I have sought to show that those philosophers who do not concede the correctness of the way in which critical philosophy marks off the limits of knowledge constantly—with a greater or lesser degree of explicit consciousness—operate with analogies in their attempts to solve the riddles of existence. It is the only aid that is left when experience refuses its service. One then conceives existence in its wholeness, or existence's ultimate ground, in analogy with certain elements, phenomena, or relations within the domain of experience. The character of the different systems, of the different metaphysical world-views, rests essentially on *which* elements, phenomena, or relations one lays at the foundation of one's analogizing.

It is often supposed that there is a forced choice between the two possibilities, that existence's inmost essence is of a spiritual kind and that it is of a material kind. But the division of the existent into spiritual and material is purely empirical. No proof can be given that existence should not be able to appear under other forms than these, so that the relation between these two forms of existence should be an Either—Or (what in logic is called a contradictory relation). Perhaps the great difficulty that shows itself to be bound up with reaching a satisfactory hypothesis concerning the relation between the spiritual and the material hangs together with the fact that existence is not exhausted in those two forms of existence, but that there are many—not to say with Spinoza infinitely many—other forms of existence. It might be that the relation between the two forms of existence we know would only be able to be understood if we knew several other forms of existence. We have at any rate not all the data for the solution of the problem of existence. Let us suppose that we knew only two colours. We should then be inclined to believe that all colour that existed at all must be one of these two. Now we know that light can be refracted in more than two ways—and yet the physics, physiology, and psychology of the colours are so extraordinarily rich in problems! Existence's light can surely be refracted in many more ways than the metaphysical systematizers have imagined. This belief (and this analogy) is at any rate as justified as that on which the idealistic world-view supports itself.¹⁶

When one does not take the probative force of analogies so strictly, it is easy enough to speculate. But one then puts images in the place of concepts, poetry instead of philosophy. Epistemologically it is of great importance that a sharp distinction be drawn between concept and image. The image may have its great value; but when it does not stand as an example or as a vivid sign for a concept, the value the image has rests on its relation to other sides of our nature than the cognitive.

16. Only reluctantly does human consciousness give up immediate intuition, as this appears in the form of sensation, memory, and imagination, in order instead to travel the road of analysis and form concepts, which can with difficulty fully make up for what was had in intuition. But it is once for all the case that the objects of the religious consciousness—when this consciousness has reached a higher stage of development—can no longer be apprehended by immediate intuition. The involuntary formation of images must constantly be altered and corrected anew, and it shows itself at last insufficient to render the eternal, infinite, and exalted essence of the religious objects. The religious consciousness here oscillates between two tendencies. On the one hand it scruples to use sensuous and human expressions of its infinite object; on the other hand it scruples to deprive immediate feeling of the living and gripping expressions in which it involuntarily finds vent. In a religious genius like AUGUSTINE, who was at once thinker and prince of the Church, one can study both tendencies in their mutual conflict. For him (as later for Schleiermacher) the expression “mercy,” used of God, has only figurative significance, because it presupposes a suffering at the suffering of others. But in order that the “souls of the unlearned” (*animæ indoctorum*) should not be hardened, Augustine nevertheless thinks that one ought to use it—thus as a kind of pedagogical anthropomorphism. Only those, he adds, who combine religion and inquiry (*religio et studium*) can dispense with the figurative expressions.¹⁷—But how far now does the figurative extend? Is there properly any expression whatever for religion’s objects that is not figurative?—If we look at religion’s history, we find especially two interesting processes of development which aim at eliminating everything figurative, and which culminate in the rejection of all definite expressions, because these are drawn from limited domains of experience and therefore make finite that of which they are used.

The first process of development lies before us in the Indian *Upanishads*. The Vedanta philosophers came to the conviction that no concept and no image could express the deity’s essence. They set up their metaphysical idealism only in order at last to take it back. The deity is “without end, without age, without shore, not outside and not inside.” It is best denoted in a negative manner (*neti, neti*): “it is neither this nor that!” And silence

is the right answer when it is asked what it is. If it could be beheld by us, it would not be what it is. It is the unthinkable—and yet that by which thought thinks! No twoness, no opposition has validity for it; therefore it cannot be known. Neither sight, word, nor thought can penetrate to it, though it works in sight, word, and thought alike. It is neither being nor non-being; it is neither known nor not-known. Only symbolically can it be expressed. But in order to keep off all sensuous ideas, which are easily brought on by symbols that have a definite meaning, the Vedanta philosophers used as an expression for the highest the syllable *Om*, which means “yes,” but does not lead the imagination in any definite direction.¹⁸

The second process of development takes place in *Neoplatonism* and is propagated from this (with the so-called Dionysius the Areopagite as intermediary) to *Christian mysticism* in the Middle Ages. Although more recent investigations have shown that there is not the complete opposition between Scholasticism and Mysticism that was earlier assumed, there is nevertheless one point in which these two medieval tendencies diverge decidedly from one another, and that is precisely the question whether there are analogies that can rightly be used to think God. The Schoolmen held fast to analogy’s justification; the Mystics rejected it. THOMAS AQUINAS teaches, indeed, that it is impossible to use any expression of God quite in the same sense (*univoce*) as that in which it is used of created beings; but there are said to be expressions that can be used of God not merely by a play on words (*pure æqvivoce*). There is said to be a kind of analogy that lies midway between univocity and mere likeness of word. It is that which rests on a causal relation, as when, for example, both a medicine is called healthy, and the one who is cured by it is said to become healthy. A relation of analogy of this kind is said to obtain between the Creator and created beings. Yet it is not a relation of likeness that could make it justified to bring the Creator and the created under the same generic concept. No, every determination—even the concept of being itself—is used in a different sense of the Creator and of the created: God stands outside every genus (*extra omne genus*).—Very clear the knowledge that is thus supposed to be possible evidently cannot be, and it is not easy to form any idea of it. For analogy is (however much one fences it about) a relation of likeness, and in all comparison there must be able to be a question of generic and specific concepts: juxtaposition by the help of analogy is in reality the formation of a generic concept. When Thomas Aquinas names, as an example of theologically applicable analogy, the one that rests on causal connection, it must be remarked that the more heterogeneous, indeed generically different, the cause is from the effect, the less do we understand the causal relation. Where the causal relation is not purely external and

purely factually imposed, there is a continuity and thereby a likeness between cause and effect which makes it justified to subsume them both under the same generic concept. Such a connection one will also on closer investigation find between the medicine and the state it produces in the organism.—The Scholastic assertion of analogy's justification therefore passes consistently over into the mystical denial of this justification. HUGH OF ST. VICTOR already taught that God is better thought by negative than by positive expressions. Later SUSO called God "*eine namenlose Nichtigkeit*"—"a nothing of all the things one can think or name" (though in himself he is "a most essential something"). And the author of *Deutsche Theologia* says: "If the perfect, sole Good [God] were something, this or that, which the creature understood, then it were not all, nor yet the only one, and it would then not be perfect either. Therefore one calls it Nothing. One means thereby that it is nothing of that which the creature can comprehend, know, think, or name."¹⁹—Mysticism was at once a movement of feeling in the direction of inwardness and an intellectual movement in the direction from image to thought and from thought to thought's limit. In that one experienced, in the strong movements of feeling, states in which no definite ideas could form, one was prepared to exercise sharp criticism of every attempt to express the highest in the form of a concept. Mysticism here meets with critical philosophy, which maintains the insufficiency of ideas in the face of that which does not appear in experience's limited form. Already in antiquity we find this kinship between criticism and mysticism, for there is a certain likeness between Carneades and Plotinus in epistemological philosophy of religion.

17. But neither Scholasticism nor Protestant theology will allow Mysticism and Criticism to be right in holding that all religious ideas are figurative. In a certain sense it is also a question of life or death. For the concept of revelation (in the strictest sense) would fall away if at certain points the difference between image and reality did not fall away. Otherwise the old problem of the relation between knowledge and things themselves would at last arise again, and the full conclusion and rest be excluded.—That expressions such as Lord or Father, used of God as absolute being, are figurative, and that the similitudes underlying these expressions fail at definite points, could not in the long run escape reflection. The Lord is Lord only in relation to slaves or servants. The word God, said Newton therefore, is a relative word (*Deus est vox relativa et ad servos refertur*). And the concept of Father presupposes not only the concept of child but also the concept of mother, although in the history of the popular religions there shows itself a tendency to push out this latter concept.²⁰ And yet both the inwardness of feeling and the need of the imagination lead again and again back to the old images, even though

one gradually acknowledges their symbolic character more readily, at any rate in theory.

When reflection develops, one passes from the more vivid and concrete designations to the more abstract. Such a more abstract designation is “personality.” One gives up the more definite characterization for a more indefinite one, which yet is also drawn from human relations.

Psychologically regarded, the determination of what the concept of personality contains will always come back to two chief traits.—Personality (the self, the I), as we know it, is in the first place characterized by its unity. All elements in its being are gathered up and connected with greater or lesser energy, and that in a more intimate manner than the elements of matter are connected according to the laws of outer nature. The very elements that are connected in personality’s unity are not absolutely produced by it; here it is more or less dependent on the conditions of life. New elements may crop up in it without its wish, though not without its own unconscious or involuntary co-operation, and it then depends on how far and in what way they are brought into connection with the elements that are already worked together.—In the second place, in every personality’s content there will be some elements that occupy a more central place and have a more constant character than others. Such central and constant elements are the ruling ends and interests, which express the will’s kind and direction. This is the real side of personality, which especially conditions the individual’s special distinctiveness.²¹—Seen both from the formal and from the real side, personal life as we know it presents an alternating relation of activity and passivity. Activity shows itself in the working-up of a content received with preponderant passivity. During this working-up the peripheral and shifting elements are more or less energetically expressed and mastered by that which in the individual personality (and in the individual period of life) is the central and constant. We know personality only as striving and struggling, as asserting itself against the resistance and the difficulties caused partly by lack or superfluity of content, partly by conflict among the elements themselves. A personality that produces all its content absolutely “out of itself”—that has no ends still unaccomplished—and that has no real resistance to overcome—is not what we understand by a personality, when we hold to psychological experience.

The dispute as to how far the deity (as this is conceived at higher religious standpoints) can be called a personal being—a dispute often designated as the dispute between theism and pantheism—rests on the fact that from the one side one idealizes and extends the concept of personality by taking away the moment of passivity, while from the other side one denies the justification of calling a being a personality when it itself produces

all its elements and therefore knows no real resistance, so that it cannot struggle, cannot strive, cannot hope.

Personal life is the highest form of existence that experience shows us. And the unity we are always at last led to assume in existence on account of its continuity and conformity to law recalls the unity in our consciousness, the formal side of personality. But for all that it is only an analogy, and one that fails at the most essential point, when one uses our idea of the limited I, which is a single link within the great world-order, to express the incompletable principle that manifests itself in the very fact that there is a world-order. And it becomes so much the more difficult to hold fast to this analogy, the greater the inclination is to think the deity as perfect, as “absolute” in the sense of finished and concluded, so that it (as Andreas Sunesøn says in his Scholastic didactic poem) can receive no increase (*natura dei, cui nil accrescere posset*). By the dogmatic absolutizing and the strong emphasis on unchangeableness, the difficulties in holding fast to the analogy with the concept of personality are sharpened and made into downright self-contradictions.

The difference between a theistic and a pantheistic conception rests, in the individual case, not merely on epistemological arguments. Involuntarily other motives play in as well, and to a great extent the difference rests on a difference in the strength with which the need to form vivid images, especially in the boundary regions, stirs in different individuals. From this side we shall later, in the psychological part of the philosophy of religion, come again to touch on this point.—As regards the expression pantheism, it must be remarked that it is used in a somewhat different manner. According to the one usage (which is maintained as the right one by an authority like EDUARD ZELLER) pantheism denotes a world-view that assumes an inner (immanent) relation between God and the world, whether one then conceives God as personal or not. According to this usage a standpoint like Lotze’s would just as well be called pantheistic as Spinoza’s standpoint. According to the other usage (which I follow) the concept has a narrower extent, in that an immanent world-view is called pantheistic only when it does not ascribe personality to the principle of unity in existence (except in poetic speech).—

To go to still more abstract expressions like force, life, substance (being) does not help; they too denote relations and thus presuppose something to which one stands in relation. Such expressions too must, when they are to be applied in the way the religious consciousness in its mythical and dogmatic forms wishes, undergo such an alteration that nothing but the bare word is left.—

It shows itself then undeniably that all analogies fail at the decisive point. We stand at

thought's limit, and it is no wonder that real concepts can no longer be formed, and that the images may indeed satisfy the individual mood, but do not permit of any consistent application. This unknowable is strongly emphasized by so-called *agnosticism*. But this tendency has an inclination to think that "the unknowable" is wholly different from everything that experience shows, so that none of experience's laws should have any significance whatever for that which is nevertheless assumed to be existence's principle. This is a dualistic assumption that cannot be grounded. Although our finite points of view and forms of thought are unable to give a determination of it, let alone an exhaustive formulation of it, they must nevertheless stand in inner connection with it, and we have no right to declare them meaningless. Our thought, our knowledge, belongs once for all to existence, has arisen within it, and is itself one of the facts that must be taken into consideration before we halt our inquiry into existence's nature. The ideas our experience leads us to develop are indeed probably very subordinate and derived in relation to the great connection into which we belong as single links; but meaningless they do not on that account become. Only we are unable to state what degree and kind of metamorphosis our points of view would have to undergo if they were to be taken up into the highest, most comprehensive connection that we could think.

The expression "agnosticism" was in its time formed by HUXLEY, so that he might have a designation ending in *-ism* like all other decent expressions for views. Were I to find such a designation for the conception I strive to make good, I should prefer to call it *critical monism*.

18. In order that concepts, analogies, and images should be able to be used to express that which at higher stages of development is religion's object, they must be subjected to an idealization and sublimation which for religious feeling easily brings coldness and remoteness with it. The religious consciousness has, to be sure, a tendency to represent its object as exalted as possible, to raise it far out beyond all finite relations. But by merely following this tendency it works against itself, since the inner, living relation to its object is made impossible. Of the Hindus an observer reports: "I have often asked: Where is the temple of the highest God? And the answer, plainly enough given with great astonishment at so unexpected a question, has always been: A temple for the highest God! What is that to mean? There is no such temple, because he can have none. He is without shape and without name, inconceivable, and we cannot worship him. We need a visible object in which our spirit can find rest."²² Within Christianity we find again the same two tendencies. In the Catholic Church there is assumed a whole graduated series of beings to whom one can turn and get one's need of a finite, limited

object for prayer and devotion satisfied, if the highest link in the series seems to us to be too remote and exalted. From God the series goes through Jesus and the Madonna down to the special saint who is active in the special kind of case or takes particular care of the individual person. In Protestantism a limit has been set to this tendency, but it has not been abolished. In a Copenhagen church it was once said in a funeral oration that God cannot help us in our great sorrows, "for he is so infinitely far away"; therefore we must hold to Jesus.

Just as the religious consciousness oscillates between literal and figurative meaning of the expressions it uses, so it oscillates between the tendency to exalt and infinitize its object and the tendency to draw the object down into the finite world as fellow-combatant and fellow-sufferer. Often the strongest feeling, the most burning devotion, turns towards the struggling and suffering God, not towards the eternal and perfect one. If now both tendencies are held fast at once in their extreme forms, there appears *the religious paradox*: God is unchangeable and changeable, eternal and becoming, victorious and beaten, blessed and suffering! Often pronouncedly religious spirits heap up such oppositions by preference, sharpening the contrasts to the utmost, partly in ecstatic admiration of the great, partly with scorn towards the thought that vainly seeks to grasp it. The chief opposition to which everything here leads back is the opposition between unchangeableness and changeableness. The typical difference of the two greatest popular religions rests on their relation to this opposition. And the opposition recurs within one and the same religion. Even he who believes in a God "with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning" may yet come to the result that "God is the most changeable of all beings."²³ The paradox does not first come forward with special dogmas, e.g. the dogma of the God-man, as S. KIERKEGAARD has sharply pointed out in his *Filosofiske Smuler*. The paradox lies properly already in every anthropomorphism, in every image that is to be more than an image. For the assertion that any image whatever suffices is an assertion that the unlimited is limited, the infinite finite. One easily forgets the paradox through the power of habituation, when one has let one's imagination settle itself comfortably in the circle of images one has formed for oneself or lived into by the help of tradition. But as soon as the surge of feeling or the speed of thought becomes stronger, the limited form is burst; and when it is nevertheless to be held fast, or rather, when one nevertheless *will* hold it fast, one approaches a *credo qvia absurdum*.

19. A Both—And has on this point too shown itself to be distinctive of the religious consciousness. But where this Both—And sharpens into the paradox, it becomes clear that the interest which has led to the development of the religious ideas in their pronounced

form cannot have been a purely intellectual interest, not the mere need to understand. In every religious standpoint, especially in the great popular religions, knowledge does to be sure play a part. Religion is in its classical times everything for the human being and satisfies his need for knowledge too. But the need for knowledge is here nevertheless subordinate to the need for life, the need to develop and preserve life. "I seek thee, that my soul may live," says Augustine to his God. Only thereby is it explained that ideas can be developed and held fast which defy the intellectual interest in clear, contradiction-free thoughts. We are led to see that the foundation of religion must be sought in other sides of the life of the spirit than in the life of pure thought.

Religion cannot be made or constructed. It grows out of life, springs from the human being's fundamental mood during life's struggle, from his will to hold fast in spite of everything to the validity of the highest valuable thing that his experiences have led him to know.

The hypothesis that religion is essentially faith in the persistence of value presents itself here naturally, after it has shown itself that religion's essence cannot be to give an understanding or an explanation of existence such as the intellectual interest demands. The riddles that science cannot solve, religion does not solve either. It has been shown that it can give no explanation of the special events (section A)—that its ideas are not fitted for the conclusion of scientific thought (section B)—and that these ideas have the character of the image, not of the concept (section C). If the religious ideas are to have any significance, it can then only be that of serving as symbolic expression for the human being's mood, longing, and wishes during the struggle of life. They are thus of secondary, not of primary, significance and origin. The philosophy of religion here combats dogmatics in a manner similar to that in which art history combats the mythology of art. What drives the artist to shape a figure is—the art historian maintains²⁴—the living joy in figures that life has shown him; he wishes now to give them new birth, perhaps in a more ideal form. But what he *calls* the figure he shapes is a subordinate question, which is often only settled long afterwards.

The intellectual interest will naturally, once it has developed, not be able to refrain from influencing the religious interest. If religion is essentially faith in the persistence of value, then this faith constantly needs ideas in order to become clear about what it means; these ideas will—perhaps slowly, but yet steadily—be worked together towards greater consistency and towards greater agreement with the ideas the human being comes to form by other roads and under the influence of other motives. The question then becomes how the two interests really stand related to one another. The intellectual

interest leads one to conceive existence as a great, unsurveyable system of causal groups and causal series; the religious interest leads one to conceive existence as a home for the development and preservation of values. Can these two points of view be united? How does value stand related to causality, the riddle of life to the riddle of the world?—Perhaps this problem is insoluble, and its solution would be the finding of the philosopher's stone. But the epistemological philosophy of religion has nevertheless, it seems, helped us to see more clearly where the problem lies. It is indeed predominantly by an indirect, negative road that epistemology can illuminate the religious problem, but this road too must be travelled if clarity is to be reached. We turn now to a direct study of religion's essence by the help of psychology. What matters is how far the hypothesis of religion as faith in the persistence of value, to which I have several times pointed, can receive a satisfactory grounding and confirmation.

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Chapter 3

Psychological Philosophy of Religion

20. Properly we have already in the preceding section made use of psychology, since there is a constant reciprocal relation between epistemology and psychology. Epistemology investigates the forms and elements of our knowledge with respect to the question of their usability for understanding existence, while psychology investigates them with respect to their factual character and their factual coming-into-being, whether they have any usability and validity or not. In the case of the religious ideas it has now shown itself that their significance cannot be that of making existence intelligible to us (in the sense in which our intellectual interest takes the word understanding). Then the psychological investigation alone stands here remaining. It may possibly lead us to see what positive significance the religious ideas do have.

The psychology of religion is a part of general psychology, a speciality within it. It stands in a reciprocal relation to general psychology.—It is a means for the latter, in that within its own distinctive domain it collects and works up material of great psychological interest. In the religious domain human beings have made some of their deepest, most intensive experiences of the soul. In religion (if it is genuine and original) all the elements of the life of the soul work with an energy and an interplay such as scarcely in any other domain. Therefore the study of the religious life of the soul is of such great importance for psychology as a whole. It is not merely the history of religion, but also—and quite as much—the individual religious life that draws the psychologist's attention to itself. In the history of religion one does not so easily get to see the forces of the soul in their original working. It occupies itself predominantly with the great types, with the forms of religion common to great groups of human beings. For the psychologist, good biographies, and especially autobiographies, of religious personalities are more instructive than the most learned works on the great popular religions. Thus—to name a few single examples—Augustine's *Confessiones*, Suso's and Saint Teresa's autobiographies belong

to the most important material of the psychology of religion. The history of individual religiosity naturally also belongs under the history of religion; but this has hitherto been predominantly occupied with studying the great types.—But the psychology of religion not merely furnishes material for general psychology. Conversely it also uses the latter's points of view and laws in its own special domain. It seeks to understand the phenomena of religious life by a purely psychological road. Here general psychology is a means for the psychology of religion. And it is especially from this last side that we must regard the psychology of religion here, where it appears as a part of the philosophy of religion. It uses the general psychological methods, so far as the subject permits, and rests on the same presuppositions as general psychology.

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3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith

Quid est quod amo, quum te amo?

AUGUSTINE.

(What is it that I love, when I love thee?)

3.1.1 Religious Experience

21. The word experience is here taken in the sense of lived experience, the finding of states, as opposed to the working-up by thought. It will first and foremost be a matter of becoming clear about what and how much can be reckoned as religious experience, and what limits this experience is by its nature subject to. I attempt in what follows to characterize religious experience from a purely psychological point of view.

22. Experience in the sense of lived experience cannot be completed so long as life lasts. It can present a series of individual states, but no completed totality, and no general proposition can appear as a fully confirmed result of experience. Totalities and generalizations are due either to a thinking working-up of what has been experienced, or else to an involuntary emphasizing of a single experience or kind of experience as decisive and all-determining. Prior to the arising of a conscious reflection it will especially be this involuntary emphasizing that lies at the foundation of what comes to stand as the results of religious experience. It lies in the nature of feeling that, when it has been awakened by a single event, it seeks to spread itself over the whole life of consciousness and to colour

all other elements in this, whether they stand in connection with that event or not. By such a *feeling-expansion* (thus I have in my *Psychology* named this phenomenon) inner states which in and for themselves have nothing to do with one another can acquire a common stamp, and a whole can come out of the series of inner lived experiences, although this series has not in itself reached a real conclusion. For different individuals and under different circumstances it may be highly different lived experiences that thus come to determine the mood of a whole inner life. However unavoidable and however significant this feeling-expansion may be, it nevertheless contains sources of error that one must be attentive to when one proceeds to a reckoning-up of what experience and lived experience have really yielded.—Naturally such a feeling-expansion is itself a lived experience; but it is derived in relation to the lived experiences whose result it is a matter of establishing.

In the debate between optimism and pessimism, for example, one will find that single lived experiences, which are assumed to be typical, determine the conception that is maintained. Although from both sides one appeals to observation and thought, the result one reaches is determined not so much by logical generalization or induction as by a feeling-expansion. The endeavour aims at holding the underlying lived experiences fast in their freshness and letting them keep their place at the centre of consciousness, fixing attention on them; then the rest follows of itself.

If faith in the persistence of value is the core of all religion, religion will not be able to be built on immediate lived experience. Immediately we come to know only the individual, definite values, as they appear according to our human and individual nature and under our special conditions of life; but about their persistence no experience can immediately instruct us, any more than it can teach us that what has the highest value for us is also the central thing in the whole of existence. What is experienced and lived through may be a *motive* for believing in the persistence of value, but not the *content* of this faith itself. Personal life, especially as it expresses itself in the great breakthroughs where new directions of life are introduced and new forms of life are born, is for us the highest valuable thing we know. The experiences we make of it we therefore use involuntarily to illuminate the whole of existence for us; it is to us as though existence in such breakthroughs revealed its hidden forces. It is a feeling-expansion that here operates. If we try to transpose it into the form of thought, it is an inference from analogy that we get—and an analogy that lies out beyond the limit where thought passes over into poetry.

23. In all experience a distinction must be drawn between what is immediately given,

what serves to explain it, and what serves to express it. These three moments, the state itself, its cause, and its expression, can lie so close to one another that they cannot be separated except by closer and more exact reflection. The relation between them is a similar one to that between a discovery, the proof of what has been discovered, and its formulation. These three moments too can approach one another, though it may be of great interest to keep them apart.

When one appeals to one's experience, one can provisionally support oneself only on *the lived state itself*. That this state may have a *definite cause* is not lived through in so immediate a manner as the state itself is lived through. Precisely when something has intervened strongly in our life of the soul and called forth great effects there, we shall be so taken up with these effects, which are indeed the very thing we immediately live through, that it will be impossible for us to form a clear and exact idea of the state's cause. The real cause always consists of a plurality of conditions and can only be established by critical investigation. It always rests on an illusion when one supposes oneself immediately to experience "the cause as cause." That a causal relation is present one cannot immediately observe; immediate observation always shows us only that the one follows *after* the other, not that it follows *from* it. The presence of a causal relation is established only when it can be shown that *only* when this definite event goes before does this definite state *unavoidably* follow after. But neither an *only* nor an *unavoidably* can be known quite immediately; they must be ascertained by comparison or by experiment. In doubtful cases it is also comparison and experiment that we resort to, and it is indeed in doubtful cases that the appeal to "experience" especially appears.

We do not begin with doubt, either in the domain of inner or of outer experience. Every rising element of consciousness is from the first taken involuntarily as valid, as the expression of reality. It presents itself with a quality of existence that is shaken only when contradictory elements too present themselves with their quality of existence. If such contradiction fails to appear, no doubt arises, and no criterion of reality or validity is needed. But when it does set in, the question becomes which of these elements possesses the true reality, and this can only be decided by there being found an unavoidable connection between one element and other elements whose validity stands fast beforehand. Thus we proceed in doubt about something in the world around us. The difference between a hallucination and a real event is discovered by the fact that the latter, but not the former, can be inserted as a link in a great, connected causal series that is tied to elements whose validity is not drawn into doubt. The more firmly connected a dream is, the more it stands for us as reality; and the more isolated a real event

stands in our experience, the more easily can we take it for a dream. What thus holds of outer experience holds also of inner. Here too an immediate experience of a causal relation is impossible. In every more deeply penetrating discussion of the significance of religious experience it will at any rate show itself expedient, if not necessary, to get the immediately lived experience itself set out with the greatest possible abstraction from the supposed cause. The strictly immediate lived experience itself cannot be any illusion. The illusory arises precisely only through an incorrect causal explanation which is confused with immediate observation. How causal explanation comes about at all we shall later have occasion to discuss.

If there is present a strongly agitated state or lived experience, it will not be exactly the need to find its cause that first of all announces itself, but rather *the need to find vent in outbursts, in exclamations, in words, or in action*. The individual then seeks after thoughts or images that can satisfy this need and give it a definite direction. It is a need for reaction that here expresses itself—a need for reaction in fear or in thanks, in love or in indignation and hatred. The manner in which this reaction takes place will be determined by earlier lived experiences and by the tradition under whose influence the human being stands. Only in especially original natures does a new formation here take place. It is such natures that become prophets or founders of religions.

By a natural displacement, that which satisfies the need for expression and reaction easily coincides with that which satisfies the need for a causal explanation, as soon as this announces itself. In the pronouncedly religious states the need for knowledge does not stir independently, and therefore not in a critical manner either; the need for expression and reaction, which is one with a need for symbolization, has decidedly the preponderance and will therefore become determinative for the content of the religious idea.

When immediate experience cannot give sure direction as to the cause of the lived experience, it can still less contain reliable information as to whether the lived experience is due to a natural or to a supernatural cause. In exact descriptions of religious states it also often becomes clearly evident that one infers a supernatural cause only because one cannot find any natural cause and does not think that one has oneself been co-operative. Thus Saint Teresa says: "I felt my soul kindled with burning love of God; this love was evidently supernatural, for *I did not know* what thus kindled it in me, and *I had not myself contributed* anything to it." It is a trait that constantly recurs among mystics and pietists, that the more they hold back (or suppose themselves to hold back) their own thought and will, the more will that which is lived through in their inner life be assumed to be

of divine origin.²⁵ There lies here the same dualistic conception at the foundation as with the concept of miracle generally. Psychological miracles stand quite on a line with physical miracles, though the belief in the former may hold out longer than the belief in the latter.

24. Religious ideas can stand in a somewhat different relation to the immediate lived experience. It may happen that the lived experience unfolds as a series of states, and that only afterwards is an idea sought which interprets it (that is to say: explains it or expresses it or both). Such an idea can be formed anew, under the impression of extraordinary lived experiences and in original, creative personalities, although even founders of religions are involuntarily guided by traditions with which their lived experiences fuse, yet in such a way that a wholly new direction in the life of the spirit can be introduced.—Most often the interpretation is drawn without more ado from the circle of transmitted ideas—ideas that were indeed possessed and known beforehand, but not particularly attended to. There are examples of persons becoming clear only afterwards that they had been “converted” or “born again,” by comparing their lived experiences with “the statements of trustworthy believers.”²⁶ The change that is noticed is interpreted by the help of tradition, for which one now first gets a practical use and which one transforms from a dead treasure into a living one. But very often the relation is such that the transmitted ideas themselves call forth the lived experiences. For most human beings religious experience is an attempt to live through, in their inner life, the states that transmitted ideas describe and demand. The ideas are thus fully finished beforehand and are merely to be converted into lived experiences. Most human beings make their religious experiences within religious communities with a more or less developed doctrine of faith. Thereby the extent of the experiences is dammed in beforehand. Lived experiences that cannot find their expression or their explanation within the transmitted circle of religious ideas stand as uncertain, or as dangerous, or even as pernicious. In theological expositions this confessional character, which is so frequent in religious experiences, appears clearly and often with full consciousness.

The older Pietism laid—in contrast to the orthodoxy it stood over against—great weight on the inner experiences. But since the Protestant Church maintains the Bible as the highest norm, the ecclesiastical pietists expressly declared that inner experience was to be subordinated to the Bible’s teaching. In his remarkable work *Theologia experimentalis* (1715) GOTTFRIED ARNOLD taught that religious experience stands under Scripture and does not denote a special principle alongside it. Experience’s significance he saw in this, that it was a practising of, or a living into, what Scripture taught. Experience

is thus not ground, but consequence and fruit, and it is to be “judged according to God’s word.” With the clarity that distinguishes Arnold, he then draws from this the conclusion that experience must occupy a different place in religion from that in science: in religion it comes after faith, in science it goes before faith. More recent theologians (for example HENRY USSING in his work *Den kristelige Vished*) have on the other hand attempted to parallel religious and scientific experience without seeing the consequences, disquieting for themselves, to which this must lead. At any rate they are compelled to concede that the individual cannot by the road of experience come to know everything that he is to believe according to his Church’s teaching. And what significance has “the common experience of the church community” for the individual, and can it rightly be called a common experience when not all make it or can make it? Besides, the Church’s teaching contains a great deal, for example the creation, the day of judgment, and so on, which no one can ever have experienced.

The confessional limitation has made religious experience, and indeed all inner experience, one-sided and imperfect. It has kept the eye away from sides of the inner life that had a full claim to come into consideration. And what in a philosophy-of-religion respect is the most important thing: it has made it psychologically inexplicable how the religious ideas came into being in the first place. Religious experience must surely be able to lead to the formation of new ideas, or at least to the valuing of other ideas than the traditionally sanctioned ones. There must in the domain of inner life be discoveries to make just as well as in the domain of outer life. The conditions of inner life change just as well as those of outer life; that follows already from the fact that there is a constant reciprocal action between the inner life and the outer. One cannot then dogmatically assume that all essential spiritual experiences should already have been made, so that all following generations have now only to practise the forms and thoughts that at a certain definite point of time were laid down. A proof that the world of the spirit is closed will never be able to be given.

25. The life-value of an idea is established both by the fact that experience leads one to form or to choose it as the expression of what has been lived through, and by the fact that holding fast to it and sinking oneself into it helps to keep one’s courage up in life’s struggle, to preserve fidelity to the best we know, and to set us tasks that carry us forward in personal development. Whether therefore an idea stands as the effect of experience or as the cause of experience, it is tested through experience. But it must be well held fast that a complete experiential proof of an idea’s life-value is present only where there has been opportunity to test whether the same experiences could not be

expressed in another way, or whether the same or equally valuable experiences could not be made in the attempt to live in ideas other than this definite one. There must not merely be a test made, but also a counter-test— and for that life very seldom gives the individual opportunity. The individual will as a rule be restricted to experiencing that certain ideas under certain circumstances have helped him or not helped him. He will not be able to prove that he could not have been helped by other ideas than those that helped him. Immediate lived experience can at any rate tell him nothing about that. And just as little can it tell him anything about whether that which did not help him might not be able to help others—or to help himself under other circumstances. Experience will here always preserve a personal-individual stamp, and “common experience” is more or less an illusion, because the different individuals in reality interpret and apply “the common” each in his own way. When there is thus already misgiving about the transition from the individual experience to the confessional, it must awaken still greater misgiving when confessional experience makes a claim to be accessible to all human beings, if only they “will” receive it. Here again there lies at the foundation the presupposition that one knows all possibilities, that is to say here: all personal circumstances and conditions.

26. Hitherto we have investigated religious experience *as* experience, that is, according to the conditions and peculiarities it has in common with other experience. Now we shall enter upon what is distinctive of *religious experience* and makes it different from other psychological experience.

Religious experience is essentially religious feeling. It is the mind’s own inner state during the course of inner and outer events that is its immediate object. But there are other experiences of feeling than the religious. In describing the nature of religious feeling it will be a matter of stating its likeness to and its difference from the most nearly related feelings.

All feeling, that is to say, all pleasure and displeasure, of whatever kind it may be, expresses the *value* which something that happens in the inner or the outer world has for us. And conversely: that has value which is the object of immediate satisfaction, or which can also become a means to such. (Cf. §3.) The concepts of end and means presuppose the concept of value, and value again presupposes a subject that can feel pleasure and displeasure. When we ascribe value to things and states, this property, like all properties, denotes a definite relation to a subject, here to one that can feel pleasure and displeasure. This property is derived in relation to other properties that things and states have; for it must be these properties that make the things and states valuable. Value is thus a property in the second power.

The different kinds of value correspond to the different kinds of feeling. One group of values hangs together with self-assertion, from its most elementary to its most ideal forms. Another group of values hangs together with devotion to beings, relations, and tasks that point out beyond the conditions of isolated self-assertion; to this belong the ethical, aesthetic, and intellectual values. The possibility of a third group of values, the religious values, rests on the fact that the two first groups of values, those of self-assertion and of devotion, are to be acquired and held fast within existence, such as it once for all is. Existence thereby comes to stand for the human being as a battlefield on which the fate of values is decided. It is a great drama that is performed, in which the human being is both fellow-player and spectator. Were he merely fellow-player, his whole energy and all his interest would be taken up by the place he himself is to fill in the drama, and he would not have time, strength, and interest to be more deeply affected by the course of the drama as a whole. Were he merely spectator, his mood at the drama's course would be purely intellectual or aesthetic. But when he is both, he will himself have values that are at stake in the struggle, and besides his own participation in this, the picture he forms of the drama's course will also affect and attune him. He will feel himself so drawn in, with his whole inmost being and with respect to the highest values he knows, to the whole great order and course of things, that there will arise in him a living feeling of displeasure or pleasure, according to the fate the values suffer. In its most immediate form this feeling finds vent in outbursts of hope and fear, admiration and disgust, joy and sorrow. Such outbursts are in all domains the simplest value-judgments there are. *This feeling, determined by the fate of values during the struggle of existence, is the religious feeling.* It is thus determined by the relation between value and reality. This relation—as it stands for the human being—determines the value the human being ascribes to existence. The religious judgments are thus secondary value-judgments, are derived in relation to the primary value-judgments in which the two first groups of values are expressed.

The religious values can—in spite of their derived character—be felt just as immediately and just as energetically as the primary ones. They will themselves be able to be the human being's central values, since the relation between value and reality is the strongest relation of tension in which the human being is placed, and which can therefore lay claim to all his energy; for what is at stake here is at last life or death for everything that has shown itself to have value for the human being. In the religious problem the concept of value appears in the second power, derived to be sure, but in the same sense in which a concentration is derived in relation to the forces that are

concentrated towards one and the same point. In religion's classical times, the time of beginnings and the time of organization, such a concentration of all interests and forces towards one point is the most characteristic trait.

And just as religious feeling, in spite of its derived character in relation to other feelings, can be just as immediate and energetic as they, so it can also appear independently over against them, react back upon them. It by no means stands merely passively related to them. There is here a constant reciprocal relation, and the degree of independence may be highly different on both sides. With greater independence the two first groups will be able to appear only at more developed stages of culture, where the spiritual division of labour has come into force. As we have earlier seen, the religious problem presents itself precisely only where the special values acquire a greater degree of independence over against that concentration of all values which is religion's distinctive character, and which psychologically finds its explanation in the fact that it is the fundamental relation between value and reality that in religion is the really determining thing.

The psychological description and analysis of a feeling must naturally not be confused with the feeling's own reality. In order to describe and analyse we need a scaffolding of concepts and points of view which the real state of feeling itself has no need whatever to know. It appears, or can appear, with a closed character of wholeness; it grows forth in the manner in which an instinct forms itself: under the influence of impressions and lived experiences which the human being cannot always account for, and which only the comparative investigation points out.

The feeling whose possibility and general character has now been described constitutes the most essential distinctive mark of all religions and religious standpoints. In relation to it all ideas are subordinate and conditioned.

One might object to this that in the great historical forms of religion it is after all an essential trait that personal beings, on whom the human being feels himself dependent, are represented as ruling in existence, and that the concept of religion therefore presupposes myth, dogma, and cult.—How one will define the concept of religion is at last a free matter. As with all fundamental definitions, it is grounds of expediency that here decide. Now it is not expedient to define a concept in such a way that one thereby cuts off important questions and problems. The religious problem becomes undeniably very much simplified if one will speak of religion only where myths, dogmas, and cult can be pointed out. But if myth, dogma, and cult always have religious significance only by being borne by a feeling such as that described above, then there shows itself a possibility that this bearing element in religion can also be and work

without procuring itself expression in myth, dogma, or cult. It is then natural to lay the chief weight on it, and the wider extent of the concept of religion therefore becomes the most natural. Great importance this question does not moreover have, since the dispute about it easily becomes a dispute about words. If one would rather avoid the word religion than use it in a wider sense, one might, as I have proposed in my *Psychology*, call the feeling that is determined by the relation between value and reality *cosmic life-feeling*. For just as the organic life-feeling immediately corresponds to and is determined by the course of life in our organism, and acquires a different character according as the organic life in us is checked or furthered, so in the feeling described there will be given a symptom of how it goes with life (so far as we know it and tie our weal and woe to it) in existence as a whole (so far as we can form a picture of it). If one will not take the word religion in the wider sense, one may call religion (in the narrower sense) a *distinctive* kind of cosmic life-feeling.—To use the word religion in the wider sense would only be unfortunate if this usage were used for unworthy accommodation to existing forms of religion. But the criticism of the existing forms of religion becomes precisely sharper if it can be shown that these in many ways come into conflict with religion's own essence and therefore point out beyond themselves. Besides, those who wish to compromise will always be able to find their ways out, and there is no reason to give up a usage that is expedient in a scientific respect because it can be misused for unscientific ends.

In his brilliant book *De l'irréligion de l'avenir* (1887) GUYAU holds fast to the narrower usage as regards the word religion, in that he will not speak of religion where myth, dogma, and cult are lacking. But he then distinguishes between *irréligion* (non-religion) and *antireligion* (religion's opposite), and his endeavour aims at establishing that "the non-religion of the future will be able to preserve the purest thing the religious feeling contained." The question is, it seems to me, whether "the purest thing in the religious feeling" is not precisely the really religious thing itself. The American philosopher of religion J. ROYCE, who stands at a different standpoint from Guyau, says in an interesting essay he has written on the young French philosopher who departed so early: "If Guyau's opinions were my own, I should without hesitation call them religious, because in them—like he himself—I should see the rationally formed consummation of what humanity's religious instinct has sought after."²⁷—We find ourselves here in the domain of fine nuances. I for my part would not have so great a misgiving as Guyau about the wider application of the concept of religion, but would not be quite so sure of my case as Royce.

27. The description of religious feeling attempted in what precedes is confirmed partly by the fact that it lets the difference between religious feeling and other feelings come

out clearly, partly by the fact that starting from it one can with ease explain the different forms that religious feeling can assume.

The more the human being is taken up with the very work of asserting himself, or the more he is absorbed in intellectual, aesthetic, and ethical interests, the more does the really religious recede, if it does not wholly disappear. Existence is then a resistance to be overcome, or an object that is understood or contemplated, or a foundation for tasks of the will.—Especially instructive here is the difference between the intellectual and the religious relation to existence. Existence presents to knowledge an unsurveyable richness and multiplicity; it contains far more than human beings will ever be able to bring under the point of view of what they call values. It realizes forms and stages of existence that go far beyond, and often stand in direct opposition to, what that which from a human standpoint stands as the valuable would demand. Intellectually regarded, this overflowing fullness is a good, because the picture of the world at which our knowledge works thereby becomes the more comprehensive, and because the endeavour is the more strongly awakened to understand the individual form or the individual stage in its distinctiveness and in its definite connection with the whole. The religious interest, on the other hand, aims at seeing this whole richness of forms and stages as the expression of the realization of great values in existence. For the religious interest the great multiplicity contains a danger and a temptation, since the reality of values cannot be pointed out so easily as if the content of existence were less luxuriant. The unsurveyable world seems to be too great for the human values. There may then here come a collision between the intellectual interest, which is always on the track of new differences and new connections and therefore rejoices in the fullness, and the religious interest, which in order to be able to hold fast to the point of view of value has a natural tendency to limit the picture of the world (which became a chief point in the epistemological philosophy of religion). This opposition comes out clearly when one compares two natures like PASCAL and SPINOZA. What terrifies the one, nature's infinity, delights and inspires the other. And yet Spinoza was in his way a religious nature. Intellectual interest can, namely, involuntarily bring with it an evaluation of existence. When existence in all its fullness nevertheless shows itself intelligible, it is indeed from an intellectual point of view a home for values, comes in a manner to meet the human spirit. It procures for us the deep joy of knowledge, which becomes of especially penetrating effect when we understand ourselves as distinctive links in the great connection.

Then arises the intellectual love which was the highest thing for Spinoza, the quiet, inspired contemplation in which everything was at last harmonized for him into a total

picture.—It will be easy in analogy with this to develop the relation between religious feeling and the feelings that stand related to it in a similar manner to the intellectual feeling. The religious relation is everywhere characterized by a striving to hold fast the persistence of the valuable in existence: whatever the valuable may be that the human being sets highest, and whatever the conception may be that the human being has of existence. Life, truth, beauty, and goodness must be presupposed to have been experienced in order that a religious relation should be possible. The religious relation comes into force when these values are compared with the rest of reality. From this one sees at once the opposition and the connection between religious feeling and other feelings. It must here be noted that what I here distinguish between as two different acts, the experience of life, truth, beauty, and goodness, and the experience of these values' relation to factual reality, need not appear at different points of time, but may coincide in one act, so that the human being himself does not become conscious of the difference. It is in the psychological description that we make this difference; it need not be made in life itself. The religious strife gets its sharp sting precisely from the fact that at the classically religious standpoint there exists no valuable life, no truth, no beauty, and no goodness outside religion; this has in its concentrated form taken up all valuable elements, so that these do not come to appear in their independent distinctiveness. This happens, as often remarked in what precedes, only when the religious problem is posed as a consequence of a beginning division of labour in the spiritual domain.

The differences between the religious standpoints may rest partly on the different values that are presupposed to have been experienced, partly on the different conception of existence that lies at the foundation, partly on the different degree of energy with which value and reality are compared, so that the relation between them can become the object of penetrating experience. These three sources of differences all spring from the given description of religion as a feeling determined by the relation between value and reality. Every exhaustive characterization of a given religion or religious standpoint will lay these three points of view at its foundation. Both in what precedes and in what follows there are examples of these points of view's significance.

28. If the conception of the world immediately showed us the highest valuable thing realized, or at least clearly showed us existence as the secure home of the valuable, no special religious feeling would arise. There would be an immediate harmony between explanation and evaluation of existence: what could be pointed out as an operative cause in the world would thereby at the same time have been pointed out as a means to the realization of something valuable. There would, to use an expression from political

economy, be no marginal utility. As it is, on the other hand—since the connection of values with the rest of reality is so great a problem—a distinctive exertion is required in order to hold fast the conviction of the persistence of the valuable.

Nor would any special religious feeling arise if the human being's capacity to work for the valuable (in himself and in existence) were unlimited. Religious feeling presupposes a striving to assert the values in us and outside us—a striving that meets resistance. The human being feels himself dependent and divided precisely in the inmost and most intimate domain. The feeling of dependence first properly arises where there is a striving to press forward. The chained animal will not feel itself dependent except when it strives to reach further out than the chain reaches. When the feeling of dependence is something other and more than a lassitude that may derive from dullness, it presupposes that one has gone to the will's limit. The lion in the cage, pacing up and down along the bars, has gone to the limit and feels its dependence; if it kept still at the back of the cage, it would feel no dependence, but would find existence far simpler and more harmonious than it now does. But in order that a religious relation should arise, it is not enough to go to the will's limit. At the very limit and in spite of the limit the wish for the persistence of the valuable must be held fast. There must form ideas of a world of values whose reality is not given up because human thought and human capacity have found their limits. There may arise an intimation that the principle of this world of values is at last one with the principle of existence's causal connection—that what makes it possible for us to find values in existence is the same as what makes it possible for us to find it intelligible.

In SCHLEIERMACHER's famous description of religion as a feeling of dependence it is not sufficiently emphasized that this dependence is conditioned by an activity, and that it arises at this activity's limit. Nor is it sufficiently emphasized that the dependence is felt with respect to the work for those values that for the human being stand as the highest and as those which in spite of everything persist and can therefore be asserted by human striving.

The role that the consciousness of sin plays in several religions is an example of the character of the religious feeling of dependence. In the consciousness of sin the human being feels the disproportion between the ideal of will that his evaluation has led him to acknowledge, and the reality of his will. It is now sluggishness and lassitude, now dividedness or dispersion, now one-sided or impatient concentration, that makes his inner reality so different from the ideal. In the consciousness of redemption or reconciliation there then dawns, often suddenly, the conviction that the valuable in spite of everything persists, persists in his own inner being and will come to be victorious there.

This inner psychological drama stands, in the highest popular religions, in Buddhism and Christianity, as the real world-drama, to whose unfolding in souls the great cosmic processes at last all minister.

3.1.2 Religious Faith

3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas

3.2.1 Religion as Drive

3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism

3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition

3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion

3.3 Dogmas and Symbols

3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience

3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.3 General Philosophical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.5 The Principle of Personality

3.5.1 The Significance and Justification of the Principle of Personality

3.5.2 Buddha and Jesus

3.5.3 Is the Principle of Personality a Principle of Growth or of Dissolution?

3.5.4 Layman and Scholar

Chapter 4

Ethical Philosophy of Religion

4.1 Religion as the Foundation of Ethics

4.2 Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture

4.2.1 Psychological Considerations

4.2.2 Sociological Considerations

4.3 Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity

4.4 We Live on Realities

Notes